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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

Corruption weakens nation's foundation: President

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11

President Ramchandra Paudel has stressed the need to combat corruption stating that it has become a hurdle to the nation's development and progress.

While addressing the 33rd establishment day of the Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority on Sunday, the president said that corruption had eroded moral values and weakened the foundation of the nation.

The Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority marked its 33rd establishment day on Sunday with the theme 'Let Us Improve Mindset, Culture and Behaviour: Corruption Will Come under Control."

On the occasion, the President said that political determinations were crucial for the prevention of corruption. He said, "The level of transparency and accountability of government will have a role in the prevention of corruption. The government with transparency and a sense of accountability can bring corruption under control."

He also drew the attention of all public entities to maintain transparency while working and making decisions. He also urged the public to embrace simplicity, integrity, transparency and good conduct.

He urged the CIAA to ensure impartiality in its investigations and subsequent prosecutions. He said that good governance was the lifeline of democracy and essential for achieving economic prosperity and social justice. He urged the CIAA to address the public interest, ensuring that high-profile individuals were not spared for abusing authority and involving in corruption activities.

Speaking at the same event, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' expressed the government's full support to the CIAA regarding its investigations and prosecutions in the corruption cases.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

President Ramchandra Paudel launching the CIAA Souvenir-2024 amid a programme organised on the occasion of the 33rd establishment day of the Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority in Kathmandu on Sunday. Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' are also present.

He said that the CIAA had played an important role in controlling and preventing corruption in all big and small events that happened in different times.

He said, "The government is committed to bringing all those responsible for corruption, no matter who they are and what posts they hold, into investigation process and under the prosecution and the government will never intervene the CIAA in its actions against corruption."

Commending the role of CIAA in promoting good governance, the Prime Minister urged the constitutional body to further prove its significance and move ahead with more dedication in the fight against corruption.

Stating that prevention of corruption was a must to meet aspirations for durable peace, good governance, development and prosperity envisioned by the Constitution, PM Prachanda said that the government had adopted a policy of zero tolerance against corruption.

He said that the CIAA which had been playing a crucial role in the fight against corruption should continue to meet people's expectations in the future as well.

Stating that corruption control was essential to advance the goals of development and prosperity in the nation, the Prime Minister stressed that the CIAA should make its role more effective in establishing a corruption-free society.

"We need to promote good conduct in family and society," he said, "There has been a delay in developing the sense of accountability and transparency in governmental bodies."

Stating that the nature, practices, intensity and dimensions of corruption were changing with the rapid development of technology, the Prime Minister urged the CIAA to seek the help of innovations in its investigations.

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2023 second hottest year for Nepal after 1981

BY INDIRA ARYAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 11

The year 2023 was the second hottest year for Nepal, according to the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology (DHM).

Earlier, 1981 was the hottest year after DHM started keeping the temperature record in Nepal from 1962.

The average maximum temperature for Nepal in 2023 was 27.9 degrees Celsius, marking a slight increase of 0.6 degrees Celsius compared to the previous normal annual maximum temperature. Similarly, the average minimum temperature was at 15.6 degrees Celsius, indicating a 0.5 degrees Celsius rise from the normal annual minimum temperature, the DHM said.

According to the DHM, Okhaldhunga witnessed an increase of 1.6 degrees Celsius from 30.9 degrees Celsius on April 28, 1999 to 32.5 degrees Celsius on June 9, 2023.

Similarly, the temperature in the Birendrachowk station in Gorkha rose by 1.0 degrees Celsius, from 38.0 degrees Celsius on May 8, 2014, to 39.0 degrees Celsius on June 8, 2023. Additionally, there was a 1.0 degrees Celsius increase in temperature at the Kanyam Tea Station in Ilam, from 29.0 degrees Celsius on July 10, 1973, to 30.0 degrees Celsius on June 3, 2023.

The recent worldwide findings have also shown that global warming has exceeded by 1.5 degrees Celsius across an entire year for the first time, with January breaking new temperature records.

Agreement made on November 4, 2016. The agreement aimed to hold 'the increase in the global average temperature to well below 2 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels' and pursue efforts 'to limit the temperature increase to 1.5 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels.'

In Nepal, a sudden increase in maximum temperature by the end of May last year led to mild to severe heatwave conditions over large parts of the country which continued till the second week of June.

Dr. Binod Pokharel, Associate Professor at the Central Department of Hydrology and Meteorology at Tribhuvan University, said that the increase in warmer years indicated a rise in drought intensity. He highlighted that over the last decade, the frequency of droughts had also escalated in the country.

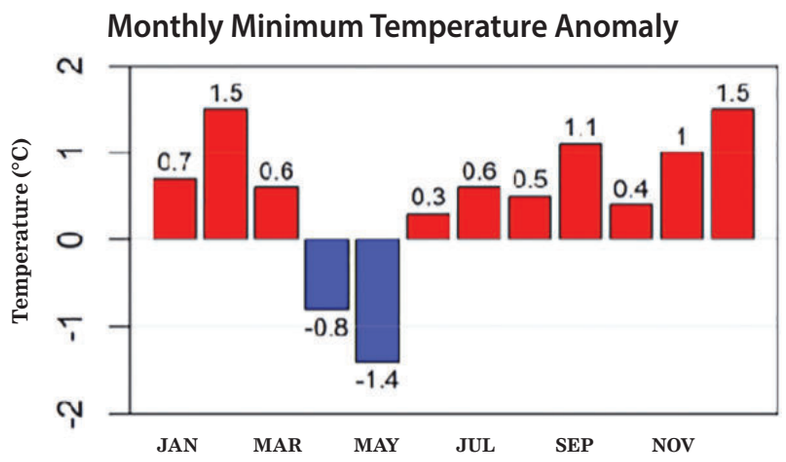
"There is a direct and indirect impact of temperature rise. The direct impact can be seen in the increase in forest fires. Warm years without rainfall may lead to an increase in forest fires, pollution, agriculture, and the drying up of springs, all of which are directly related to people's health and the ecosystem," Dr. Pokharel said.

The DHM record shows that the regional temperature variations were significant, with the southern part of the country experiencing average maximum temperatures above 30 degrees Celsius while the northern part recorded temperatures below 18 degrees Celsius.

Bibhuti Pokharel, Chief of the Climate Section under the DHM, said that several parts of Nepal experienced hot days and heat wave conditions during different periods of the year. The heat wave was persistent over central and western parts of the country before the onset of monsoon over the region until the third week of June.

Specifically, the southern regions, particularly districts like Kapilvastu, Rupandehi and Chitwan faced mild to severe heat waves, with temperatures exceeding 42 degrees Celsius for several days.

Several meteorological stations broke previous records for extreme temperatures, highlighting the intensity of the heat waves experienced in 2023, the DHM said.



Source: DHM

According to the European Copernicus Climate Change Service (C3S), the first month of 2024 was 1.66 degrees Celsius hotter, marking the warmest January and breaking yet another heat record after the troubling extremes of 2023.

And Nepal is no exception to this global temperature rise, said Ajay Dixit, an expert on issues of water, climate change and disasters.

"The warming trend is similar in Nepal as well. The impact of temperature rise is seen globally as the impact due to the absence of a transition to clean energy from coal fuel," Dixit said.

According to him, the world has failed to implement the Paris

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HOUSE BODY ASKS TO ADD HUMAN RESOURCES AT TIA'S IMMIGRATION

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11

The State Affairs and Good Governance Committee of the House of Representatives has given various instructions to the government to solve the problems that have surfaced in immigration at the Tribhuvan International Airport.

A meeting chaired by Committee's President Ramhari Khatiwada on Sunday gave instructions to amend the existing law related to immigration and human trafficking and solve the visa problem, among others.

Similarly, the meeting instructed to coordinate with the Ministry of Federal Affairs and General Administration to manage sufficient manpower at the airport.

The Committee also instructed to make necessary arrangements to make the airport less crowded.

President Khatiwada said that the government would take the necessary measures to strengthen open cross-border security.

In the meeting of the Committee, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Narayan Kaji Shrestha complained that the transferred employees had refused to go to work at the airport's immigration.

DPM Shrestha said that the government would not backtrack from investigating the embezzlement of 10 ropanis of land belonging to the Bansbari Leather Shoe Industry.

He said that although the Court ordered to release the convicts and to investigate by keeping them out of custody, the government (police administration) was committed to conducting a thorough and impartial investigation.

In response to the question raised by the parliamentarians regarding the assault on the employees at the airport, Inspector General of Police Basant Bahadur Kunwar replied that the matter was under investigation.

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Evading VAT is a crime: Dr. Mahat

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Damak, Feb. 11

Finance Minister of the Federal Government Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that the economy has returned to the post-COVID-19 normalcy and foreign exchange reserves were at comfortable position. Speaking at the fifth Damak Mahotsav organised by Damak Chamber of Commerce and Industry, in Damak, Jhapa, on Sunday, he mentioned that the government had worked through a challenging times when making the economy dynamic was an uphill task.

"The economy has gradually returned to the normal. Many problems of the economy have been solved, but some are yet to be addressed and they pose further challenges to us," he said.

According to him, there was a rumour that Nepal would become



Sri Lanka (where there would be an exhaustion of foreign exchange reserves and the country fails to finance it import trade and debt servicing), but now the country has enough foreign currency that can finance the import trade for a year.

However, the Finance Minister maintained that the capital that has been accumulated in the system has not been mobilised for capital formation and business financing. "This is the result of mobilising a large amount of loans at a cheaper rate to unproductive sectors during the COVID-19 pandemic period. A large amount of capital was mobilised in unproductive areas like capital market and real estate. We are facing the impact of the same," he said.

FM Dr. Mahat said that the economy had also been affected due to a sharp fall in the stock market and land transactions. At the same time, the Nepal Rastra Bank started tightening the credit flow and the interest rate increased which created complication and the economic recession.

According to him, various economic and financial misconducts increased in the cooperative sector during the period of economic slowdown. Some people took advantage of the poor regulation of the cooperatives and misused the funds in saving and credit cooperatives.

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Lumbini government aims to create 200,000 jobs in two years

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Deukhuri, Feb. 11

The Lumbini Provincial government has begun the process of preparing the second periodic plan of the province.

It has begun the initiative to solicit stakeholders' opinions and suggestions for the plan that would be implemented from the coming Fiscal Year 2024/25 for the next five years.

The Provincial Planning Commission (PPC) Lumbini has also asked the concerned sectors to help in the planning of the plan as the allocation of the budget for various development programmes and activities will be based on this document.

At the same time, the provincial government is looking for the role of the private sector in the periodic planning



especially in the area of the industrial and commercial sector development. Dr. Sudan Kumar Oli, Member of the PPC Lumbini, urged the private sector to focus on production and job creation as the government aims to increase income generation activities and create more jobs in the upcoming years.

He said, "The private sector should be informed about the potential of each district in Lumbini and the support that the government should be provided. The government will proceed according to their suggestions and plans."

Vice-Chairman of the PPC, Dr. Nahakul KC, informed that the Lumbini government prepared the framework for the Chief Minister's Economic Development Programme, and claimed that it would create jobs by increasing, promoting and commercialising local productivity.

The provincial government aims at creating about 200,000 jobs through the promotion of agriculture, and youth entrepreneurship in service and other areas in the next two years

"The government has a clear strategy and is aware that it cannot make much progress by moving ahead alone. It needs the help of the private sector in finding markets and selling local products," said Dr. KC.

Health Minister of Lumbini, Raju Khanal, informed that the development model of the province would be included in the periodical plan. According to him, the government closely understands the problems of industrialists and will cooperate with them in solving them.

Although it is positive to have a policy dialogue with the private sector while the government is preparing the second periodical plan, the representatives of the private sector have urged the government to pay attention to the implementation of the plan.

Krishna Prasad Sharma of the Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry in Lumbini said that issues of increasing production and boosting economic activities should be included in the periodic plan.

BULLION
(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 118,000
Worked Gold	: Rs. 117,450
Silver	: Rs. 1,390

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,085.82
Total Amount	: 4,085,678,472.16
No. of Share	: 10,571,199

NEPSE posts double-digit falls, turnover stands at Rs. 4 billion

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11



The benchmark of the stock market, NEPSE, posted a double-digit fall on Sunday, the first transaction day of the week. The index decreased by 10.50 points to close at 2,085.82 points on Sunday.

The sensitive index which measures the performance of group 'A' companies decreased by 3.89 points to close at 374.75 points. A total of 10,571,199 shares worth Rs. 4.08 billion of 305 companies were sold in 83,877 transactions today.

The sub-indices of all groups, except hydropower, development bank and mutual fund decreased in today's transaction. Sub-index of the manufacturing and processing group saw the highest fall of 168 points followed by the hotels and tourism and non-life insurance whose indices decreased by 88.08 points and 42.62 points respectively.

Similarly, trading group sub-index decreased by 33.52 points, life insurance by 30.50 points, microfinance by 16.04 points and finance by 9.03 points. Sub-index banking group decreased by 9.01 points, others by 0.41 points and investment by 0.22 points.

> The sub-indices of all groups, except hydropower, development bank and mutual fund decreased in today's transaction.

However, the sub-index of hydropower increased by 6.01 points, development bank by 3.77 points and mutual fund by 0.01 points.

Share prices of NIC ASIA Growth Fund-2 decreased by 10 per cent, Unilever Nepal Limited by 7.14 per cent and Gurans Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha by 7.13 points. However, share prices of Samaj Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha increased by 10 per cent, Kutheli Bukhari Small Hydropower by 9.99 per cent and Trishuli Jal Vidhyut Company by 6.71 per cent.

SWASTIMA BECOMES BRAND AMBASSADOR FOR XIAOMI



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11

Xiaomi has announced Swastima Khadka as the brand ambassador for Xiaomi in Nepal.

Swastima is a leading actress in the Nepali movie industry and is renowned for her acting ability and relatability. "She will represent Xiaomi, amplifying the brand's resonance with consumers across the nation," said the company in a statement.

Swastima expressed her happiness about being the brand ambassador of the company, and said, "Xiaomi's dedication to innovation and quality resonates with me, and I am eager to contribute to their journey in Nepal. I hope we grow together exponentially on this journey."

Manu Manaswi, Country Manager of Xiaomi Nepal, said that Swastima's versatile talent and widespread appeal make her an ideal fit for Xiaomi.

"We believe that her association with Xiaomi will bring a new dimension to our brand, connecting with consumers on a deeper level," he said.

90% compensation distributed to land acquired for Marsyangdi dam

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tanahun, Feb. 11



Distribution of compensation for the land of the dam side of the Marsyangdi hydroelectric power plant located in Aanbukhaireni Rural Municipality of Tanahun has almost been completed.

The distribution of compensation has reached the final stage after the compensation has been decided to permanently acquire the land of various people located on the banks of the dam of the hydropower plant in Eklephant of Tanahun.

The meeting of the compensation determination committee chaired by the Chief District Officer on July 6, 2023, had decided to provide compensation for the land of 13 people and houses of five people.

According to Pashupati Gautam, chief of the centre, more than 90 per cent of the compensation has already been distributed and the rest will be completed soon. He said only the families who have not yet left their homes were not paid the compensation.

District Administration Office, Tanahun, has informed that the land compensation has been determined at the rate of Rs. 18.49 million per hectare. According to the office, around 9 ropanis and 10 anas of land will be acquired at that place.

Around Rs. 217 million will be provided for land acquisition. According to the DAO, around Rs. 178 million will be distributed for the land and Rs. 39.9 million for houses.

The project's dam, which has a power generation capacity of 69 megawatts, decided to acquire the land after the settlement of that place was flooded and eroded.

Due to the danger of human casualties, locals of that place have been demanding compensation and relocation to a safe place.

Shukra Chuman, Chairman of Aanbukhaireni Rural Municipality, said that farmers were happy after the funds were released for the distribution of compensation, which they had been demanding.

Hearing on bill to relocate Washington Capitals begins

AP
Richmond, Va. Feb.11

Legislation underpinning a plan to relocate the NBA's Washington Wizards and NHL's Washington Capitals across the Potomac River to northern Virginia easily cleared an early hurdle in the state legislature Friday.

Lawmakers on the Virginia House Appropriations Committee voted 17-3 to advance the measure, a top priority of Republican Gov. Glenn Youngkin, to the floor of the House of Delegates. Though the bill passed overwhelmingly, several senior Democratic legislators took care to say that their support for the measure at this point was in the interest of keeping negotiations over the deal going.

"This process is going to take the rest of our session at a minimum to enact or not enact this legislation," Democratic Del. Mark Sickles of Fairfax County, who supported the bill, said before the committee vote.

The legislation could result in a legacy-defining project for Youngkin, a former college basketball player. Virginia is the nation's most populous state without a major pro-sports franchise, something government officials of both parties over the course of decades have sought to change.

Youngkin and entrepreneur Ted Leonsis, an ultrawealthy former AOL executive and the CEO of the teams' parent company, Monumental Sports and Entertainment, announced in December that they had reached an understanding on a deal to relocate the Capitals and Wizards.

The plan calls for the creation of a $2 billion development in the Potomac Yard section of Alexandria that would include an arena, practice facility and corporate headquarters for Monumental, plus a separate performing arts venue, all just miles from Capital One Arena, where the teams currently play in Washington.

Monumental and the city of Alexandria would put in upfront money under the terms of the deal, but about $1.5 billion would be financed through bonds issued by a governmental entity this year's legislation would create.

The bonds would be repaid through a mix of revenues from the project, including a ticket tax, parking fees, concession taxes, income taxes levied on athletes performing at the arena, and naming rights from the district, among other sources.

Proponents say those sources will more than cover the debt. But about a third of the financing would be backed by the "moral obligation" of the city and state governments, meaning taxpayers could be on the hook if the project revenues don't come through as expected. Critics of the project, including some who spoke against the bill Friday, asked why any tax subsidy was appropriate.

"This is a bad deal for every taxpayer in Virginia. We are saddling our children and grandchildren with 40 years of debt payments to help a billionaire get wealthier and wealthier," said Andrew Macdonald, a former Alexandria city council member and an organizer of the Coalition to Stop the Arena at Potomac Yard, which held a rally on Capitol Square a day earlier.

The committee advanced a substitute version of the legislation that was initially introduced by Democratic Del. Luke Torian. It included a newly added provision that would require legislators to sign off on the deal again next year in order for the legislation to go into effect, something critics of the project cheered.

Monica Dixon, president of external affairs and chief administrative officer for Monumental, said the company was "very pleased" with Friday's developments.

"We'll take a look at it, but don't expect we'll have any major concerns," Dixon said of the revised bill, which is likely to see further revisions as it goes through the legislative process.

Democratic legislative leaders, who control the General Assembly, have generally signaled openness or even optimism about the passage of the arena legislation this year. But they have stopped short of a full-throated endorsement of the project, both citing concerns still to be worked out and making clear the proposal is a bargaining chip in broader discussions about their own priorities.

Sen. L. Louise Lucas, who chairs the Senate finance committee, has said she wants consideration of increased public school funding, toll relief for her Hampton Roads region and legalized recreational cannabis sales in conjunction with the arena deal.

A Senate committee had at one point been expected to take up that chamber's version of the bill on Thursday. But the hearing was delayed, and by Friday afternoon it was unclear when the bill might be heard ahead of Tuesday's "crossover" deadline by which non-budget bills need to clear their chamber of origin.

Julie's Cake launches online service

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11

Julie's Cake and Pastry, which has been in the bakery business for the last two decades, has started an online service to facilitate easy access of its customers to its products.

"Established in September 2003 at Kandevtasthan in Lalitpur, Julie has been embracing the latest technology every time in its two-decade journey, and has now launched its own e-commerce platform," said Julie Pradhanang, one of the founders of the outlet.

Through Julie's online service launched on Sunday, customers can easily order their favourite and premium quality bakery and cake items at home. Already, Julie has partnered with reputed platforms like Foodmandu, Muncha, Thamel.com, Bhoj and more.

Bean dips, enchiladas, taco kits among items linked to listeria outbreak

AP
New York, Feb. 11

More foods are being recalled in the wake of a deadly outbreak of listeria food poisoning, including snack foods that may be part of Super Bowl Sunday party menus.

Seven-layer bean dip, chicken enchiladas, cilantro salad dressing and taco kits sold at stores like Costco, Trader Joe's and Albertson's are part of the growing recalls of products made by Rizo Lopez Foods, Inc., of Modesto, California, federal health officials said.

Dairy products made by Rizo Lopez Foods are the source of the listeria outbreak that has killed two people and sickened more than two dozen since 2014, according to the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.

Health officials investigated illnesses in 2017 and 2021, but were only able to confirm the source based on new laboratory and inspection information when more people fell ill in December, officials said.

Rizo Lopez Foods recalled more than 60 soft cheeses, yogurt and sour cream on Monday that are sold under the brands Tio Francisco, Don Francisco, Rizo Bros, Rio Grande, Food City, El Huache, La Ordena, San Carlos, Campesino, Santa Maria, Dos Ranchitos, Casa Cardenas, and 365 Whole Foods Market.

The recalled foods were sold to food service providers, retailers and at deli counters nationwide.

The federal government said consumers should consult the Food and Drug Administration's table of recalled products for updated information about descriptions, sizes and best-by dates. The U.S. Department of Agriculture also issued a public health alert for certain Amazon kitchen burritos that contain ingredients made by Rizo Lopez Foods.

About 1,600 people are sickened by listeria food poisoning every year, according to the CDC. Listeria infections can cause serious illness and, in rare cases, death. People who are pregnant, older than 65 or have weakened immune systems are particularly vulnerable. Symptoms — like muscle aches, fever and tiredness — usually start within two weeks after eating contaminated foods, but can start earlier or later.

The CDC said consumers who have the recalled products should throw them away and thoroughly clean the refrigerator, counters and other contact sites. Listeria can survive in the refrigerator and easily contaminate other foods and surfaces.

Sauraha Food Festival begins targeting Valentine's Day

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11



PHOTO: TRN

Preparations is in progress for Sauraha Festival.

The 18th Sauraha Food Festival kicked off in Sauraha, a tourist town of Chitwan, on Sunday. Member of the House of Representatives Hari Dahal inaugurated the five-day festival organised by the Restaurant and Bar Association of Nepal (REBAN) Sauraha amidst a function today.

The festival is being held here every year on the occasion of Valentine's Day to support Chitwan's tourism, according to the REBAN, Sauraha. Lawmaker Dahal said that the government had not paid attention to the development of tourism in Sauraha.

He said that he had been trying for a year for the recognition of Sauraha's tourism as an industry and the establishment of an office of the Tourism Board. Former Minister and Provincial Assembly Member of Bagmati Province Krishna Prasad Khanal said that since the National Park Act has not been amended for a long time, a gap of mistrust has deepened between the CNP and the people.

Pralhad Sapkota, Mayor of Ratnanagar Municipality, said that Sauraha in Chitwan National Park, the third most touristic city in the country, has been affected by the National Park Act. Central Vice President of REBAN Sanghrasha Bista demanded the government should recognise the restaurant business as an industry as well.

President of the Regional Hotel Association of Sauraha Ganga Giri said that Sauraha's tourism was returning to its normalcy, and said that about 225,000 tourists entered Chitwan in the current fiscal year so far. President of REBAN, Sauraha Dhruba Giri said that festival was organised on the occasion of Valentine's Day for the tourism development of Chitwan, including Sauraha

The festival has been made special by promoting food, music and culture together, he said, adding that the activities of the festival have been carried forward to bring the tourism of Sauraha back to the pre-COVID-19 situation.

Stating that Sauraha Food Festival has its glorious history, he said that the Food Festival, which is being organised to promote tourism in Chitwan including Sauraha, is contributing to the overall tourism development of the district.

General Secretary of REBAN, Sauraha Nabin Nepal, said that the festival was organised with the aim of identifying Sauraha as a tourist destination at the national and international levels, continuing the programme of the bright Sauraha, and beautifying the Sauraha tourist route with the income from the sale of entrance tickets.

It is expected that daily about 5,000 visitors will visit the five-day festival and generate business of Rs. 30 million. The festival running in the main market of Sauraha will continue until February 15, 2024.

Growing negativity is creating awkward situation: Gurung

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bharatpur, Feb. 11

Minister for Law, Justice and Parliament Affairs Dhanraj Gurung has said that the negative comments and understandings which have, of late, been increasing in Nepal, have created an awkward situation.

Speaking at a press conference organised by the Nepali Congress, Chitwan Publicity Department on Sunday in Bharatpur, Minister Gurung expressed the opinion that the negative comments made for the sake of popularity should end.

"There is a trend of speaking for cheap popularity with the hope of getting media coverage as if only negative things were being done from every place," he said.

"When we open the files of corruption, they speak against it, when we were arresting gold smugglers, there was also opposition and similar was the situation when efforts were made to end the network human trafficking, everywhere there is only negativity."

Minister Gurung said that the government could not do as much work as it wanted. "One ministry thought it was necessary and sent a draft of a bill to the law ministry, but after six months the draft bill did not come, there is a problem.

How will the country get the required laws by holding draft bills for a long time?" Minister Gurung complained.

He said that the challenging and chronic conditions seen in the present coalition government were gradually decreasing. "When we came to the government, there was a situation that now Nepal will also tread the path of Sri Lanka. After we have been included in the Cabinet, we are slowly bringing the national economy on the right track from that awkward situation," Minister Gurung said.



PHOTO: TRN

Minister for Law, Justice and Parliament Affairs Dhanraj Gurung at a press conference with officials.

"I will not say that it has been completely good. Even now, it is still in a difficult situation. But it is better than when we joined this government," he said.

Minister Gurung, who is also the vice president of the Nepali Congress, said that the NC's campaign in the community started by the party would correct the weaknesses of the Congress and move forward.

"Politics is like a snow-fed river. Politics does not dry up. There are ups and downs in the long journey of politics. People come and go. People who believe in democracy need not be disappointed. Public opinion may go on changing according to the changed context," Minister Gurung said.

He also said that it would be wrong to go to people with the old mindset. "We have no right to work in the old style, we have to show progress when we are in government," he said.

FIVE SWINDLERS HELD IN FALSE ASSURANCE OF SHARING PROFIT OF ONE-KG GOLD

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11

Police have arrested five persons along with Rs. 775,000 in cash for cheating individuals in the false assurance of sharing one kilogram of gold.

They were detained in Bhaktapur in a joint operation conducted by the Kathmandu Valley Crime Investigation Bhaktapur Branch and the District Police Range Bhaktapur on Saturday.

The arrested fraudsters were identified as Chhulthim Lama, 38, of Barhabishe Municipality-5 of Singhupalchowk district, Rajendra Tamang, 33, Chin Bahadur Lama, Dawa Dundup Tamang, 31, and Jit Bahadur Tamang of Sindhupalchowk.

According to Bhaktapur Police Range, the group had telephoned Binita Thapa Magar, 24, of Doramba Rural Municipality-4 in Ramechhap, who has been temporarily residing in Madhyapur Thimi Municipality, on January 31, and informed her about investment in the one-kg gold they had brought and allured her that there was profit in doing the business and share the profit in equal.

Later on, the group collected Rs. 275,000 from Bhaktapur Municipality-20 on February 3 and Rs. 500,000 on February 5 and switched off their mobile phones.

The victim then filed a written complaint of cheating against them on February 9. Following the investigation, the group members were arrested from Bode, Bhaktapur on February 10. When the police conducted a search operation, different amounts of cash equal to the seized amount were confiscated from the arrested persons.

NEWS BRIEF

Man held with illegal weapon

Siraha: Police have arrested a man along with a homemade illegal weapon in Siraha Municipality-7 in Siraha district. The arrested person has been identified as 20-year-old Saroj Kumar Yadav of Aurahi Municipality-4 in Mahottari district.

When the police received information that there was a dispute with Sanjeet Kumar Yadav, 22, of Aurahi Rural Municipality-3, the police deputed from the ward police office, Siraha, detained Saroj, who was involved in the dispute, and while searching his body, found the pistol with him and arrested him.

Detainee found dead in Rajbiraj prison

Saptari: A detainee who was under investigation on rape charge was found dead in the Rajbiraj prison.

Prison officiating administrator Sadananda Das said that 19-year-old Devendra Mandal of Hanumannagar Kankalini Municipality-6, Saptari district was found hanging inside the prison toilet Sunday morning. Mandal was sent into detention at the Rajbiraj prison for further investigation on the charge of abducting and raping a 15-year-old girl on the night of July 29, 2023.

(TRN)

DEMOCRACY FOSTERS DEVELOPMENT: CM KARKI

RSS
Dharan, Feb 11

Chief Minister of Koshi Province Kedar Karki has said democracy is essential for development.

Addressing a seminar organised by the Democratic Thoughts Society Koshi Province chapter on 'Challenges of Federal Republic: NC's Role', in Biratnagar on Saturday, CM Karki said, "In a democracy, there is debate on thoughts. In the absence of democracy, there is only order."

Development works are incomplete when there is no debate on any issue, he said, adding that the Koshi Province government was planning to set up a think tank to forward intellectual dialogues. The think tank will focus on how the potential of health, education, agriculture and technology could be unlocked, he added.

He hoped that the institute would play a significant role in the province's development.

1.52 million vehicles fined for violating rules

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11

The traffic police offices from across the country have taken action against 1.52 million vehicles in the first six months of the current fiscal year.

According to Police Headquarters, Naxal, Rs. 797.1 million fine has been collected from operations conducted by traffic police from July to the end of December last year. Of the total fine, Rs. 323.3 million was collected from the Kathmandu Valley alone.

Similarly, Rs. 78. 7 million was collected from Koshi Province, Rs. 10.5 from Madhes, Rs. 78. 8 million from Bagmati, Rs. 81.8 million from Gandaki, Rs. 93.8 million from Lumbini, Rs. 15.6 from Karnali and Rs. 24.2 million from Sudurpashchim Province.

Deputy Inspector General and Spokesperson for the Police Headquarters, Bhim Prasad Dhakal, said that Rs. 151 million was collected from trucks and tankers, Rs. 92.5 million from buses and minibuses, Rs. 189 million from cars, jeeps and vans, Rs. 28.8 million from tractors, Rs. 311 million from motorcycles and Rs. 25.3 million from the three-wheelers and other types of vehicles within the period.

According to the statistics of the Central Police Office, the highest amount of revenue was collected in the Kathmandu Valley and the lowest in the Karnali Province.

DIG Dhakal said that the amount of revenue has been collected for driving under the influence of alcohol and driving at high speed, not maintaining road lane discipline, carrying more passengers exceeding the capacity, parking randomly, charging more than the prescribed fare, not having the necessary documents and driver's license.

According to the statistics of the Police Headquarters Naxal, most of the vehicles involved in the actions were motorcycles.

Mesh fencing begins in Chitwan to check wildlife intrusion

BY SHANTA ADHIKARI
Chitwan, Feb. 11

Mesh fence construction has begun in the wards at risk of wildlife in and around Chitwan National Park.

Construction of mesh fencing will start within a three-kilometre area covering wards 23, 24, 27, and 28, where there is a high risk to wildlife. The estimated cost of the first phase of the project was Rs. 27.9 million, but a contract was signed to construct the fencing at Rs. 18 million through a tender process. According to the agreement, the work is expected to be completed by July 29, 2024. According to Renu Dahal, Mayor of Bharatpur Metropolitan City, construction work on mesh fencing has begun in a three-kilometre area covering four wards at the outset.

Ward Nos. 6, 8, 9, 11, 12, 13, 22, 23, 24, 27, and 28 of Bharatpur Metropolitan City are connected to the river and park areas. All these wards are at risk of wildlife, but the work has been started from the ward with the highest risk.

Gole Sunshine JV Sukedhara Kathmandu has signed the construction contract for the first phase of the project.

Mayor Dahal laid the foundation stone for the first phase of the work on Friday. Speaking at the foundation laying ceremony, Dahal said that a new tender would be opened after conducting an immediate survey in the wards and areas with exemptions and demands from the residents.

She said that due to the risk of floods, erosion, and the presence of wild animals in the wards adjacent to the forest areas, the construction of embankments along the Narayani and Rapti rivers with mesh nets had started.

Upon completion of these two projects, concerns regarding wild animals will be addressed, she added. Elephants, rhinoceroses, boars, and other wild animals have been causing significant losses to human wealth in the settlements connected to the rivers and park areas of West Chitwan every year.

Dhanusha water resources drying up earlier than usual

BY VIJAY KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Feb. 11

Wells, springs and other water sources in the northern region of Dhanusha have started drying up before the onset of summer. If it does not rain in winter, locals are likely to face acute water shortages in the coming days.

Rivers, water canals, wells and hand pumps have started drying up in the areas including Bateshwor, Mithila, Dhanusadham and Ganeshnatha Charnath Rural Municipalities. The drying up of water sources is sure to escalate water scarcity as well as poor agricultural yields in these areas.

Manoj Kumar Mahato, a farmer from Ward No. 3 of Mithila Municipality in Dhanusa, said, "Water sources started drying up as early as February. I used to irrigate my farm by pumping the water from the well, but this year I feel that I won't be able to irrigate my farm, and how will I manage the expenses if I won't be able to grow and sell vegetables?"

He is worried that after the wells, which he used for irrigation, dried up, he would not be able to grow vegetables this time.

Lack of irrigation has left fields where farmers used to grow seasonal vegetables barren, Mahato said.

Ram Ashish Mahato, chairman of Bateshwar Rural Municipality, said that after wells on the premises of Devaki Secondary School dried up, students and teachers have to carry drinking water from their homes.

He informed that with the drying up of wells by mid-January, water availability has fallen by 30 per cent in the local water sources. It is predicted that by April and May, up to 90 per cent of the water sources will dry up.

He attributed the depletion of water sources in the Ratu, Badhari, Auhai and Jalad Kamala rivers in recent years to uncontrolled excavation of riverine products, destruction of Chure hills and rampant deforestation.

Suresh Sharma, an environmental engineer and forest official from the Madhes Province Forest Department, stated that due to the absence of rain this year, water sources in the Tarai region have been gradually drying up

The land's reduced capacity to retain water, resulting from urbanisation, forest clearance, and alterations in river courses, has further contributed to the depletion of groundwater reserves.

"We have neglected the utilisation and conservation of our natural resources. If we fail to protect the uncontrolled excavation of rivers and deforestation, the crisis will continue to escalate day by day," he added.

Dr. Vijay Kumar Singh Danuwar an expert on the Chure region blamed the declining underground water levels for the problems as he noticed reduced water levels in numerous locations.

He said that the deep ditches left in the rivers by the contractors of riverbed materials and construction of embankments to prevent flooding, and destruction of water sources in the Chure resulted in the drying up of wells and hand pumps.

Dr. Danuwar further said that this problem of water has arisen because the level of groundwater has dwindled. Stating that the Chure area is a natural water reservoir, he informed that if the rainwater can be retained in the Chure area by building an embankment on the river flowing through the Chure, the underground water level can increase.



PHOTO: TRN

Women collecting water from a well in Dhanushadham.

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THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Treasure your relationships, not your possessions.
- Anthony J. D'Angelo

EDITORIAL

Hydropower Prospects

In 1911, Nepal installed 500-KW Chandrajyoti Hydro-electric power station in Pharping in south west of Kathmandu during the reign of prime minister Chandra Shumsher. The country's first ever power project was a milestone in giving a push to the nation's economic development. It was set up almost 29 years after the world's first power plant was established in USA in 1882. This was indeed interesting that the country was reeling from the dark age in terms of political freedom and social equality but the rulers of the time showed their inclination to illuminate the country albeit in a limited scale. Despite this early initiative, there was no headway in electricity development for over a century owing to lack of technology, investment, human resources and more importantly, the inhospitable political climate.

The country was able to generate just 750MW of electricity by 2012. This also tells why the country failed to prosper notwithstanding the frequent political changes over the decades. Electricity is the prerequisite for the industrial development. The industrial countries have achieved notable economic growth on the back of surplus energy that can be generated from water, solar, wind, and thermal and nuclear plants. Nepal is endowed with abundant water resources but it could not tap it even when it entered an era of openness and economic liberalisation since the early 1990s. The electricity production requires huge investment and cutting-edge technology. In our case, labyrinthine bureaucratic process and policy adjustment also come in the way.

However, the country has witnessed headway in electricity production in the last one decade with the adoption of favourable government policy, increasing participation of the private sector and access to foreign market. The growing call for embracing green energy also created atmosphere conducive to investing in electricity generation. The rising global warming, caused by the excessive use of fossil fuels, has posed a threat to the sustenance of human, animal and plants on the earth. Over 95 per cent of the population has access to electricity, while the country's installed power capacity has reached almost 3,000MW. Nepal has also started exporting power to India in rainy season. Now it is poised to generate 28,500 MW power in next 12 years.

After Nepal government inked an agreement with India to export 10,000 MW electricity to the southern neighbour in next 10 years, the private sector has been further encouraged for investing money in the clean energy. In its Energy Development Roadmap and Action Plan, the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation plans to export 15,000 MW of electricity to India and Bangladesh, and distribute 13,500 MW to domestic consumers out of 28,500 MW to be generated by 2035. The ambitious target to produce such a large quantity of electricity in little over a decade may be challenging but it is not unachievable given that around 269 hydropower projects – big and small – are under construction in the country.

It requires about $47 billion investment to meet this target. The government mulls to manage $24 billion from domestic investors and $23 billion from foreign direct investment. Now it should focus on policy reforms that include formulation of necessary acts and regulations, and making amendments to the existing policies to attract both the domestic and international investors. Timely clearing of trees in the project sites and construction of transmission lines facilitate the completion of hydro projects within stipulated time and avoid the cost overruns. One door system is essential to deal with all associated administrative procedures. All stakeholders including government, domestic and foreign investors, lending institutions and local community should cooperate for this.

Wellness Is Not Healthcare

ROSS HARPER

Mental health and mental wellness, though often used interchangeably, cater to distinct markets. Mental health services are primarily focused on diagnosing, treating, and managing mental illnesses. As such, labels like "psychologist," "psychiatrist," and "therapist' are protected titles that describe individuals who are qualified to deliver specific mental health services. State licensing boards oversee these mental health providers in the U.S. By contrast, mental wellness services embrace a more holistic and altogether less regulated approach to enhance overall well-being through stress relief, mindfulness, and lifestyle improvement.

Both these industries drive positive social impact, but they are not the same thing. Despite clear industry distinctions, the digital world often blurs the lines between mental health and wellness solutions. In popular app stores, both types of apps are found under the same categories, such as "Health & Fitness," without clear differentiation. This conflation can be detrimental to users, with many seeking clinical results from wellness apps. This raises concerns about the mismanagement of serious health conditions and undermines the impact of more validated digital tools.

Applying the rigorous standards of healthcare to digital apps would see many fall short on real-world clinical evidence. There are concerns that these apps could be downright harmful, as was found by the National Eating Disorder Association when an untested chatbot named Tessa recommended calorie restriction and dieting to users with a diagnosed eating disorder. Overnight, many mental health apps would need to reclassify themselves as mental wellness apps due to their lack of regulation or insufficient evidence to meet the high bar for healthcare services. In particular, I would anticipate that many so-called 'mental health' chatbots would hastily update their websites to read 'mental wellness' chatbots.

In the regulated healthcare industry, business models are clear and often scrutinised to protect patient privacy and prevent conflicts of interest. Many health and wellness apps, however, rely on business models that include selling data to third parties and generating revenue from advertising, practices that would be unacceptable and unethical in a regulated healthcare context. With stricter regulation, care providers would gain greater confidence around incorporating digital solutions into their treatment plans, knowing that "health" apps meet the necessary standards for quality assurance and safety.

This isn't just about restriction; it's about ensuring quality and safety, giving stakeholders confidence in digital tools and allowing them to realise their benefit in practice. For example, recent research showed how a regulated AI tool improved clinical outcomes and health economics across 250,000 patients in NHS mental health services. Yet, for almost two years, experts remained unconvinced of the efficacy of wellness apps for mental health and continued to look for clinical evidence that demonstrates otherwise.

The frequent use of taglines like "an AI psychologist in your pocket" for products with no clinical basis undermines the professionalism and governance of certified mental health providers. In a more regulated digital health environment, the use of protected titles or implications of clinical efficacy by uncertified apps would be curtailed, reinforcing the value of professional mental health services and ensuring users are not misled by inaccurate advertising or promotion.

I firmly believe wellness apps can benefit many people. However, we need to be realistic about what these solutions can and cannot do. We must not allow ourselves to slip into an over-reliance on wellness tools for serious health problems. Healthcare deserves its own tooling, backed by solid evidence and meeting the highest standards. Let's redefine our current digital landscape to make it clearer for everyone.

- Psychology Today

Soft News On Hard Facts

P Kharel



TIDE OF TIMES

How the credibility of news outlets erodes is showcased by the manner in which the Ukraine war is being covered by some of leading international news media. For more than 23 months since Russian troops entered neighbour Ukraine, many media organisations, originating in major Western capitals and cities, gave a slant that the invading forces fought with World War II weapons and suffered regular troop desertions amid heavy casualties.

It now appears clearer that the severe setbacks Ukrainian military recorded were kept deliberately low. Hundreds of thousands of their men and women in uniform were killed. The mainstream news media originating in the countries supporting Volodymyr Zelenskyy simply did not discuss Ukraine's losses at length. Yours humbly had from the beginning said in this column that, a prolonged war or not, Moscow could not afford to lose it. For a defeat at a crucial juncture of contemporary history would pose grave risk to President Vladimir Putin's Russia's regained superpower status.

Certain to obtain one more tenure in office in the elections next March, Russian President Vladimir Putin enjoys a high public approval rating even after 24 years in power. The former head of the country's top intelligence agency, who served as vice-president served out the remaining one year in the presidential chair after Boris Yeltsin stepped down a year before his second term was to end.

Regressive reticence

Putin's foreign detractors had for years been very reticent in acknowledging at length the rapid economic strides and technological advances that Communist China had been making. Respect for information providers steadily falls when double standards get exposed. For the role that the media, as an effective unit of civic society, becomes a persistent suspect and hence a crippled public platform.

In a leader last fortnight, "The media is the message", *The Economist* viewed that the discovery and dissemination of information mattered a lot to politics. It quoted James Maddison, often hailed as the Father of the United States' Constitution: "A popular government without popular information, or the means of acquiring it, is but a Prologue to a Farce or a Tragedy; or, perhaps both. Knowledge will always govern ignorance." The magazine warned that political camps existing in separate information universes "tend to demonise each other".

Crises spawn half-truths and outright lies, depending upon an actor's desperation and penchant for shedding qualms for the sake of narrow expediency that offers an immediate respite whatever the long-term blow to the perpetrator's image and damage to moral integrity. In context comes the concern expressed by The Guardian, a British news outlet, which described the mass slaughter of journalists in the course of the "many atrocities". It quoted the Committee to Protect Journalists that reported on "the deadliest conflict for media workers". About 70 journalists, including several foreign, suffered violent deaths and 100 others were injured in three months.

Prior to the latest war, Israeli military had killed 20 journalists in 22 years. No one was charged or held accountable for the deaths. In addition, more than 100 United Nations aid workers were already killed in the conflict, recorded as the highest toll in a single conflict in the UN's entire history. And Israel is the single-largest recipient of the US aid since almost its inception as an independent state more the 75 years ago.

> If unchecked, the new normal would eat into the news receiving habits of audiences across the mass media landscape while the lofty qualities of the Fourth Estate would be lauded in theory but flouted in practice.

A telling story questioning the existing mode of media functioning relates to the extremely small trickles of information flow out of war-ravaged Ukraine since February 2022. A new interpretation of newsroom practice offers a disturbing attitude. It bids a good bye to view-free journalism that has "lost" relevance. Selective criticism is cowardice that dares to pick on soft target and cringes at the sight of the powerful, however corrupt and of degraded in character. Younger journalists question whether objectivity is desirable at all in the digital world. Wesley Lowery, a Pulitzer-winning journalist at American CBS News, dismissed "view-from-nowhere", "objectivity"-obsessed both-sides-ism journalism as a failed experiment.

Former British Home Secretary David Blunkett later confirmed having advised Prime Minister Tony Blair in March 2003 to bomb the Al Jazeera television transmitter in Baghdad. He had no worry about it, as it was a war. "In a war, you wouldn't allow the broadcast to continue taking place." In April 2003, a US missile hit an electricity generator at Al Jazeera's office in the Iraqi capital and killed a reporter while wounding another staff member. The broadcaster's offices had previously been hit by US missiles in Kabul during the invasion of Afghanistan.

Disturbing outlook

Racism and other forms of discrimination are issues afflicting news organisations. In July 2020, American journalists protested on the streets against their employers. Some journalists at *The New York Times* described a senator's call for a show of military force to check the protesting journalists as "black nytimes staff in danger". While more than 150 *Wall Street Journal* employees claimed that they "find the way we cover race to be problematic", no less than 500 employees at *The Washington* Post supported demands for fighting against "racism and discrimination" at their paper.

Surveys conducted by American agencies persistently indicate that less than half of American and European audiences trust what their media report. An example of an unwelcome normal can be gleaned from a recent prattle by the Associated Press news agency. Remarking on Putin's reelection decision, it wrote: "But 71 is an age when death or serious illness are hardly distant concerns for the man who has ruled Russia for 24 years."

Facts are facts: in the US, hopefuls for the November elections, Joe Biden, 81, and Donald Trump, 77, make Putin a youthful man of 71 whose popularity ratings average 70 per cent compared with the American duo's barely 40 per cent even if in power for not more than four years each. If unchecked, the new normal would eat into the news receiving habits of audiences across the mass media landscape while the lofty qualities of the Fourth Estate would be lauded in theory but flouted in practice—a tragic condition for both the public and the media.

(Professor Kharel specialises in political communication.)

Upgrade Facilities For Tourists

Ballav Dahal



With Nepal's tourism industry bouncing back fast in the post-COVID situation, it is necessary for the government and the private sector to focus on creating new tourist attractions and highlighting the country as a preferred destination in the global market. The nation holds unlimited tourism potentials in view of its unrivalled natural and cultural heritages. But these resources have not been utilised fully. However, the country's tourism industry has now been on a track to recovery. In 2023, the nation was able to receive more than one million foreign travellers. The government has announced the period between 2023 and 2033 as the Visit Nepal Decade with a goal of developing the country into an important tourist destination. Under this decade-long tourism campaign, the government aims to attract more tourists and generate one million extra jobs in the tourism sector within two years. To materialise this ambitious plan, much needs to be done when it comes to diversifying tourism, upgrading the existing tourist facilities and services, marketing destinations and revising policies and laws.

The government has also planned to increase average daily tourist spending to US$ 125 from the prevailing US$ 48. It has given thought to this bearing in mind that the number of tourists alone is not important. How much money the nation earns from tourism holds significance. But considering the current scenario, this goal is unlikely to be achieved as no momentous steps have so far been taken to sustain tourism growth. It is imperative to work out plans for lengthening the stay of tourists in order to increase incomes from tourism. For this, creation of new tourist spots is essential. We cannot attract repeat visitors without offering something new to them to experience.

Gradual recovery

The first month of 2024 proved to be quite favourable for Nepal's tourism. Last month, the nation hosted as many as 79,100 international tourists. With a total of 24,139 visitors, India topped other tourist generating countries. In January last year, more than 16,400 Indians came to Nepal. In the same month last year, the country was able to welcome 55,074 tourists only. As the saying goes—morning shows the day, the year 2024 may also be quite encouraging for the country's tourism. China emerged as the second key tourist source market for Nepal, with 7,267 tourists, while a total of 7,047 travellers from the United States came here to experience the Nepali hospitality in January this year.

It goes without saying that the tourism sector had suffered an unprecedented loss due to COVID-19 for two consecutive years starting 2020. The nation had witnessed an alarming level of loss in tourism-related jobs and revenue owing to the protracted global public health crisis. Several tourism entrepreneurs had also been displaced while much investment had been wasted. However, with a gradual recovery of the tourism business in the country, many of such jobs have now been restored. If tourist arrivals continue to show their upward trend, the tourism sector is likely to provide more new jobs.

> Once the Nepal government opens a dollar bank account, potential foreign tourists can apply for e-visa from any part of the world, enabling them to pay for visa fees through any foreign bank.

Yet, the situation is still challenging because of the existing global recession. This may have a negative impact on the tourism industry for 2024 as well. When any financial crisis emerges, travellers do not want to spend much time and money. In such a tricky situation, they tend to visit only short-haul destinations instead of long-haul ones. Therefore, Nepal now needs to make additional efforts to tap the boundless India and Chinese markets. With increased air connectivity between Kathmandu and numerous cities of these immediate neighbours, Nepal can bring in more tourists from there.

As part of its initiatives to facilitate the movement of tourists into Nepal, the government has now launched an e-visa system and online visa fee payment services. Such digital services are expected to have positive implications for the nation's tourism sector. Because of these services, customers are not required to visit the immigration office physically for applying for visa, paying fee, and receiving new visas. However, they now need to go for the Nepali banking channel to make payments for e-visa.

Hassle-free service

Once the Nepal government opens a dollar bank account, potential foreign tourists can apply for e-visa from any part of the world, enabling them to pay for visa fees through any foreign bank. Upon approval, they will get a notification with QR code through their respective email accounts. Then, they can pay for visa. When those tourists get to the immigration desk at the Tribhuvan International Airport (TIA), they get an e-visa sticker attached to their passport. So, unlike in the past, the visiting tourists will get a hassle-free serve while getting through the immigration process. Those foreign visitors willing to trek to restricted areas like the Upper Mustang can also get permit without delay. The Department of Immigration (DoI) must ensure that these electronic travel automation services are available without any interruption so as to facilitate tourists.

It is needless to say that tourism, as a multi-dimensional industry, contributes to creating employment opportunities, making foreign exchange earnings and supporting numerous auxiliary sectors such as horticulture, vegetable farming, animal husbandry and handicraft. This sector also plays a crucial role in enhancing social development as tourists are found extending their support for constructing schools and hospitals in remote rural areas of the country. Having recognised the importance of tourism, the provincial and local governments have also prioritised it. However, they still need to go a long way for the development of this vital sector of the national economy.

(The author is a deputy executive editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 12, 1974

Fertilizers To Farmers

Birgunj, Feb. 11: The Agriculture marketing Corporation of Birgunj made available 2777 metric tonnes of chemical fertilizer to the farmers in the first six months of the current fiscal year, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Follow Suryodaya's Example



PHOTO: PREM ADHIKARI/TRN

This is in reference to the news report titled *"Free bachelor education to Ilam women"* published in this daily on Feb.11. For four years now, Suryodaya Municipality in Ilam district has been providing free bachelor's education to its women to try to discourage them from dropping out of study once they get married.

This initiative has worked to ensure women's access to education, which is crucial. "When a man gets educated, he alone is educated. But when a woman gets educated, entire family gets educated," goes the saying. And when education is free, enrollment gets a boost.

The news comes at a time when education is getting increasingly expensive, depriving many of the fundamental right. Education serves as a tool to end discriminations prevalent in society. In today's age, without good education, it's hard to function in the society and get decent employment.

This commendable step should be emulated by other municipalities in other districts as well.

Raju Aryal Jhapa

TAILPIECE

Bubba & Earl were in the local bar enjoying a beer when the decided to get in on the weekly charity raffle. They bought five tickets each at a dollar a pop.

The following week, when the raffle was drawn, each had won a prize. Earl won 1st prize, a year's supply of gourmet spaghetti sauce and extra-long spaghetti. Bubba won 6th prize, a toilet brush.

About a week or so had passed when the men met back in the neighbourhood bar for a couple of beers. Bubba asked Earl how he liked his prize, to which Earl replied, "Great, I love spaghetti! How about you, how's that toilet brush?"

"Not so good," replied Bubba, "I reckon I'm gonna go back to paper."

Russia launches 45 drones in mass barrage of Ukraine

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Feb. 11

Russian forces launched 45 drones over Ukraine Sunday in a five-and-a-half-hour barrage, officials said, as Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy continued the reshuffle of his war cabinet as the war enters its third year.

In a statement, the Ukrainian air force said it had shot down 40 of the Iranian-made Shahed drones over nine different regions, including on the outskirts of the country's capital, Kyiv.

The five-and-a-half-hour attack targeted agricultural facilities and coastal infrastructure, officials for Ukraine's southern defense forces wrote on Telegram. They said that a strike in the Mykolaiv region had injured one person, sparking a fire and damaging nearby residential buildings.

Another person was injured in Ukraine's Dnipropetrovsk region when a blaze broke out due to falling debris from a destroyed drone, said the head of the region's military administration, Serhiy Lysak.



PHOTO: AP

Firefighters extinguish a fire after a Russian attack on a residential neighborhood in Kharkiv, Ukraine Saturday, Feb. 10, 2024.

The strikes come as Zelenskyy continues his shakeup of military commanders in a bid to maintain momentum against attacking Russian forces.

Kyiv announced Sunday that former deputy defense minister Lt. Gen. Alexander Pavlyuk would become the new commander of Ukraine's ground forces. The post was previously held by Col. Gen. Oleksandr Syrskyi, who was named Thursday as the replacement for Ukraine's outgoing military chief, Gen. Valerii Zaluzhnyi.

New presidential decrees also named Yurii Sodol, the former head of Ukraine's marine corps, as the new commander of Ukraine's combined forces; Brig. Gen. Ihor Skibiuk as commander of Ukraine's air assault forces; and Maj. Gen. Ihor Plahuta as commander of Ukraine's territorial defense forces.

Incoming commander-in-chief Syrskyi has signaled that his immediate goals include improving troop rotation at the front lines and harnessing the power of new technology at a time when Kyiv's forces are largely on the defensive.

In a statement on Telegram Saturday, Zelenskyy said that he hoped to "reboot" the upper levels of Ukraine's armed forces with experienced combat commanders.

"Now, people who are well-known in the army and who themselves know well what the army needs are taking on new responsibilities," he said.

Iran marks 45th anniversary of the Islamic Revolution

AP
Iran, Feb .11

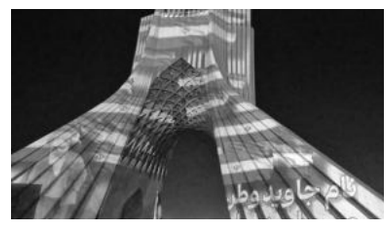


PHOTO: AP

People attend the annual rally commemorating Iran's 1979 Islamic Revolution under the Azadi (Freedom) monument tower in Tehran, Iran, Sunday, Feb. 11, 2024.

Iran marked Sunday the 45th anniversary of the 1979 Islamic Revolution amid tensions gripping the wider Middle East over Israel's continued war on Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

Thousands of Iranians marched through major streets and squares decorated with flags, balloons and banners with revolutionary and religious slogans.

In Tehran, crowds waved Iranian flags, chanted slogans, and carried placards with the traditional "Death to America" and "Death to Israel" written on them. Some burned U.S. and Israeli flags, a common practice in pro-government rallies.

Processions started from several points, converging at Azadi Square in the capital. State TV showed crowds in many cities and towns, claiming that "millions participated in the rallies" across the country.

The military displayed a range of its missiles, including the Qassem Soleimani and Sejjil ballistic missiles, the Simorgh satellite carrier and drones at the square where people took selfies with them.

During the celebrations, a paratrooper jumped from a plane while displaying a Palestinian flag.

Many high-ranking Iranian officials attended the celebrations in Tehran, including hard-line President Ebrahim Raisi.

He addressed the crowds in Azadi Square and called on the United Nations — in a speech broadcast by state TV — to expel "the Zionist regime," as the crowds chanted: "Death to Israel." Raisi also said, "the bombing of Gaza has to be stopped as soon as possible."

The commander of the powerful Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps General Mohammad Salami and Gen. Esmail Ghaani, the head of the expeditionary force of Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard, also took part in the celebrations, while the head of the Judiciary body, Gholamhossein Mohseni Ejehi, was at the rally in the central city of Isfahan.

Finns go to polls for presidential run-off

AFP
Finland, Feb. 11

Voters in Finland are choosing Sunday between two experienced politicians to be their next president, whose main task will be to steer the Nordic country's foreign and security policy now that it is a member of NATO, following Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

Former prime minister Alexander Stubb, 55, on the center right, and former foreign minister Pekka Haavisto, 65, from the green left, largely agree on Finland's foreign policy and security priorities.

These include maintaining a hard line toward Moscow and Russia's current leadership, strengthening security ties with Washington, and the need to help Ukraine both militarily and at a civilian level. Finland shares a 1,340-kilometer (832-mile) border with Russia.

Unlike in most European countries, the president of Finland holds executive power in formulating foreign and security policy together with the government, especially concerning countries outside the European Union such as the United States, Russia and China.

The head of state also commands the military — particularly important in Europe's current security environment and the changed geopolitical situation of Finland, which joined NATO in April 2023 in the aftermath of Russia's attack on Ukraine a year earlier.

A politician with the conservative National Coalition Party, Stubb took the top spot in the first round of the election on Jan. 28 with 27.2% percent of the votes, ahead of the eight other candidates, and is the favorite to win the presidency.

Stubb led the government in 2014-2015 and earlier held several other Cabinet posts.

Haavisto, the runnerup in the first round, was Finland's top diplomat in 2019-2023 and the main negotiator of its entry into NATO. A former conflict mediator with the United Nations and a devout environmentalist, Haavisto took 25.8% of the votes in the first round.

A runoff was required because none of the candidates got more than half of the votes in Jan. 28's first round.

UN's IMO working 'tirelessly' to solve Red Sea crisis: head

AFP
London, Feb. 11

The International Maritime Organization (IMO) is working "tirelessly" to solve the Red Sea crisis, which is severely disrupting the global transport of goods, its head Arsenio Dominguez told AFP.

Yemen's Huthi rebels, supported by Iran, have launched dozens of attacks against ships in the Red Sea since November, targeting boats headed for Israel in an act of "solidarity" with inhabitants of the Gaza Strip, which is in the grip of the war between Israel and Hamas.

Despite retaliatory strikes by the US and UK, the rebels are still launching attacks, firing at US ship "Star Nasia" and UK vessel "Morning Tide" on Tuesday.

The IMO, the United Nations agency responsible for security at sea, is working to ensure that "parties continue to talk so that the situation does not degenerate any further, and we can return to a safe maritime environment," Panama-born Secretary General Dominguez told AFP on Thursday.



PHOTO: AFP

The IMO's objective is therefore to 'provide practical and operational measures so that ships can continue to operate', Dominguez said.

"We are working tirelessly to coordinate action that will lead to a resolution," Dominguez added from the IMO's London headquarters.

The region is crucial for the global transport of goods, with around 12 percent of global maritime trade normally passing through the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, which controls access to the southern Red Sea.

Many shipowners have decided to stop operating in the Red Sea, instead sending their ships on the longer route around the south of Africa.

But "this is not the ideal solution", admitted Dominguez, as it increases the cost of transport, and ultimately the price of the cargo.

"We now have more than 60 percent of the annual tonnage the normally goes through the Suez Canal now going around southern Africa," he explained.

Insurance has also gone up and increased fuel use is creating additional costs.

There is also a human impact, with crew having to spend extra days at sea, said Dominguez.

The IMO's objective is therefore to "provide practical and operational measures so that ships can continue to operate", he added.

Despite the headwinds, Dominguez said he remained "optimistic" about a resolution to the conflict.

PRISM

Doctor reunited with her ring

A doctor in Britain was reunited with her diamond ring after the precious item took a nearly 100-mile journey in the pocket of a pair of scrubs.

Suraj Shah, an anesthetics registrar at the Royal Free Hospital in London, said he donned a freshly-laundered pair of scrubs as he prepared for his shift.

"As I put the scrubs on something clattered to the floor and a colleague spotted the ring and alerted me," Shah said in a news release. "At first I thought maybe one of the nurses here had lost the ring and I put the word out through the nurse in charge. I checked with the doctors as well but nothing so I contacted our facilities team."

The facilities team contacted its laundry service and discovered a doctor had reported a ring missing after leaving it in the pocket of her scrubs at the West Suffolk NHS Foundation Trust in Bury St. Edmunds, nearly 100 miles away.

Radhika Ramasamy, a consultant anesthetist, said she had put the ring in her pocket about five days before it was discovered by Shah.

world's tallest matchstick sculpture.

Guinness World Records accepts matchstick tower

A French man's Guinness World Records dreams were reignited when the organization reversed its decision and awarded him the title for world's tallest matchstick sculpture.

Richard Plaud spent eight years building a 23.6-foot model of the Eiffel Tower from 706,900 matchsticks, but the record-keeping organization initially told him he was disqualified from the world record because he used matchsticks that weren't commercially available.

Plaud started the sculpture with store-bought matches, but ended up striking a deal with a company to sell him 33-pound boxes of headless matches.

Guinness World Records officials said earlier this week that they would review the decision, and Mark McKinley, director of central records services, said Plaud has now been awarded the title.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1689 – The Convention Parliament declares that the flight to France in 1688 by James II, the last Roman Catholic British monarch, constitutes an abdication.

1909 – New Zealand's worst maritime disaster of the 20th century happens when the SS Penguin, an inter-island ferry, sinks and explodes at the entrance to Wellington Harbour.

1945 – A devastating tornado outbreak in Mississippi and Alabama kills 45 people and injures 427 others.

1946 – World War II: Operation Deadlight ends after scuttling 121 of 154 captured U-boats.

2004 – The city of San Francisco begins issuing marriage licenses to same-sex couples in response to a directive from Mayor Gavin Newsom.

2019 – The country known as the Republic of Macedonia renames itself the Republic of North Macedonia in accordance with the Prespa agreement, settling a long-standing naming dispute with Greece.

American allies worry the US is growing less dependable, whether Trump or Biden wins

AP
London, Feb 11

As chances rise of a Joe Biden-Donald Trump rematch in the U.S. presidential election race, America's allies are bracing for a bumpy ride.

Many worry that a second term for Trump would be an earthquake, but tremors already abound — and concerns are rising that the U.S. could grow less dependable regardless of who wins. With a divided electorate and gridlock in Congress, the next American president could easily become consumed by manifold challenges at home — before even beginning to address flashpoints around the world from Ukraine to the Middle East.

French President Emmanuel Macron's recent verdict was blunt: America's "first priority is itself."

The first Trump administration stress-tested the bonds between the U.S. and its allies, particularly in Europe. Trump derided the leaders of some friendly nations, including Germany's Angela Merkel and Britain's Theresa May, while praising authoritarians such as Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Russian leader Vladimir Putin. He has called China's Xi Jinping "brilliant" and Hungary's Viktor Orbán "a great leader."

In campaign speeches, Trump remains skeptical of organizations such as NATO, often lamenting the billions the U.S. spends on the military alliance whose support has been critical to Ukraine's fight against Russia's invasion.

Biden, in contrast, has made support for Ukraine a key priority and moral imperative. But Biden's assertion after his election in 2020 that "America is back" on the global stage has not been entirely borne out. Congressional Republicans have stalled more military aid for Ukraine, while America's influence has been unable to contain conflict in the Middle East



PHOTO: AP

U.S. President Joe Biden walks with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Kyiv, Ukraine, Monday, Feb. 20, 2023. As chances rise of a Biden-Donald Trump rematch in the U.S. presidential election race, America's allies are bracing for a bumpy ride, with concerns rising that the U.S. could grow less dependable regardless of who wins.

Thomas Gift, director of the Centre on U.S. Politics at University College London, said that whoever wins the presidential race, the direction of travel will be the same – toward a multipolar planet in which the United States is no longer "the indisputable world superpower."

Most allied leaders refrain from commenting directly on the U.S. election, sticking to the line that it's for Americans to pick their leader.

They are conscious that they will have to work with the eventual winner, whoever it is — and behind the scenes, governments will be doing the "backroom work" of quietly establishing links with the contenders' political teams, said Richard Dalton, a former senior British diplomat.

But many of America's European NATO allies are worried that with or without Trump, the U.S. is becoming less reliable. Some have started to talk openly about the need for members to ramp up military spending, and to plan for an alliance without the United States.

German Chancellor Olaf Scholz said he was "currently on the phone a lot with my colleagues and asking them to do more" to support Ukraine. Germany is the second-largest donor of military aid to Kyiv, behind the U.S., but Scholz recently told Die Zeit that the country couldn't fill any gap on its own if "the U.S.A. ceased to be a supporter."

Russia, meanwhile, is busy bolstering ties with China, Iran and North Korea and trying to chip away at Ukraine's international support.

Macron also suggested American attention was focused far from Europe. If Washington's top priority is the U.S., he said its second is China.

"This is also why I want a stronger Europe, that knows how to protect itself and isn't dependent on others," Macron said at a January news conference.

Trump does have supporters in Europe, notably pro-Russia populists such as Hungary's Orbán. But former British Prime Minister Boris Johnson raised some eyebrows when he argued recently that "a Trump presidency could be just what the world needs."

Johnson is a strong supporter of Ukraine in its struggle against Russian invasion, whereas Trump has frequently praised Putin and said he'd end the war within 24 hours. However, Johnson said in a Daily Mail column that he didn't believe Trump would "ditch the Ukrainians," but instead would help Ukraine win the war, leaving the West stronger "and the world more stable."

Bronwen Maddox, director of the international affairs think tank Chatham House, said arguments like that underestimate "how destabilizing" Trump has been, and likely would continue to be if reelected.

"For those who say his first term did not do much damage to international order, one answer is that he took the U.S. out of the JCPOA, the deal to curb Iran's nuclear program. Iran's acceleration of its work since then has left it a threshold nuclear weapon state," she said during a recent speech on the year ahead.

Biden was a critic of Trump's Iran policy but hasn't managed to rebuild bridges with Tehran, which continues to flex its muscles across the region.

Dalton, a former U.K. ambassador to Iran, said prospects for the Middle East would be "slightly worse" under Trump than Biden. But he said divergence on the region's main tensions — the Israeli-Palestinian conflict and Iran's ambitions — would be limited.

"No U.S. administration is going to make a serious effort to resolve differences with Iran through diplomacy," Dalton told The Associated Press. "That ship sailed quite some time ago."

Palestinians and their supporters, meanwhile, implore Biden to temper U.S. support for Israel as the civilian death toll from the war in Gaza climbs. But hard-liners in Israel argue the U.S. is already restraining the offensive against Hamas too much.

Itamar Ben-Gvir, Israel's far-right national security minister, recently said Biden was not giving Israel his "full backing" and that "if Trump was in power, the U.S. conduct would be completely different."

Much like its allies, America's rivals are not openly expressing a preference for the election outcome.

Trump developed a strong rapport with Turkey's Erdogan, calling them "very good friends" during a 2019 meeting at the White House.

Yet Turkey-U.S. relations were fraught during his tenure. The Trump administration removed Turkey from its F-35 fighter jet project over Ankara's decision to purchase Russian-made missile defense systems, while Trump himself threatened to ruin Turkey's economy.

Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov told CBS in January that he doesn't "believe there will be any difference" between a Trump and a Biden presidency. He argued that Russia-U.S. relations have been going downhill since George W. Bush's administration.

China, where leaders' initial warmth toward Trump soured into tit-for-tat tariffs and rising tensions, little changed under Biden, who continued his predecessor's tough stance toward the United States' strategic rival.

Zhao Minghao, a professor of international relations at Fudan University in Shanghai, said that for China, the two candidates were like "two 'bowls of poison.'"

Gift, from University College London, said the move to a more fractured world is "going to happen regardless of whether Donald Trump or Joe Biden is elected."

BUDHATHOKI'S DEMISE CAUSES IRREPARABLE LOSS: DEUBA

RSS
Jhapa, Feb. 11

Nepali Congress (NC) President Sher Bahadur Deuba has said that demise of NC central committee member and former minister Keshav Kumar Budhathoki caused an irreparable loss to the party and the nation.

In a condolence meeting organized on Sunday on the seventh day of Budhathoki's demise in Jhapa, President Deuba said Budhathoki's roles in development, party building, democratic movement and constitution making will be remembered once and always.

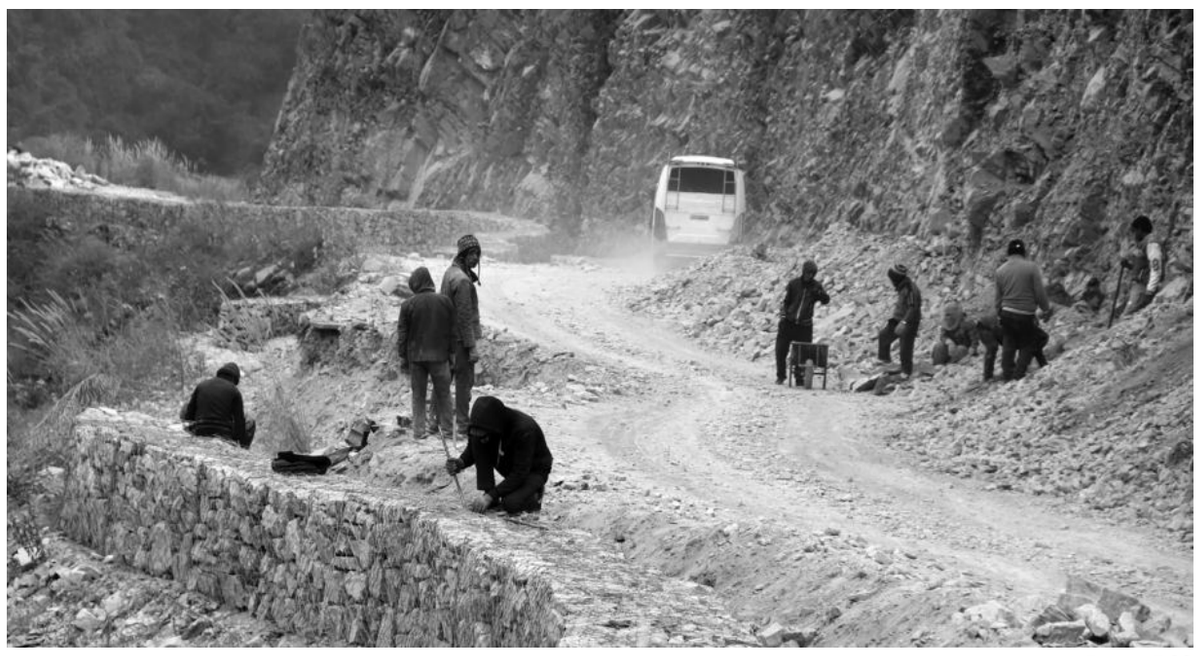


PHOTO: RSS

Workers are busy constructing the Chandragiri-Chitlang road section in Kathmandu.

Issues of public concern raised at NA

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11

The lawmakers in the National Assembly expressed their concerns on various issues ranging from the encroachment of the government lands to the process initiated to appoint the Vice-Chancellor in Tribhuvan University and the plight of the earthquake victims in Jajarkot and Rukum West districts on Sunday.

They also drew attention of the Upper House on other pressing issues like maintaining good governance and safeguarding the nation's integrity and well-being.

During the special session today, MP Mahesh Kumar Mahara from CPN (Maoist Central) specifically highlighted encroachments of government lands such as Bansbari Leather Shoes, Lalita Niwas, and Tikapur. Emphasising the importance of collaboration for social justice and good governance, Mahara called for swift resolution of the transitional justice (TRC) bill. Stating that the treatment of conflict victims remained unresolved, he urged to provide justice to the families of the injured and missing individuals who played a key role in political changes.

MP Uday Bahadur Bohara from the CPN (United Socialist) shared the ongoing challenges faced by the victims of the earthquake that struck Jajarkot in western Nepal on November 3 last year. He expressed concern that restoration efforts had not been effective, leading to continued suffering, especially from diseases such as pneumonia during the winter. Bohara requested to provide immediate relief and rehabilitation for the affected areas.

BPKIHS resumes OPD services and classes

BY NISHA RAI
Dharan, Feb. 11

B.P. Koirala Institute of Health Sciences in Dharan resumed OPD services and academic activities after a protest lasting for 28 days.

The Institute's doctors, teachers and staff halted OPD and academic services on January 19 demanding the authorities to start the promotion process that was halted for the past 15 years.

Additionally, students were also on a relay hunger strike demanding their regular academic activities.



The protest was lifted after reaching a 6-point agreement between the management of B.P. Koirala Institute of Health Sciences and the Joint Struggle Committee of Teachers Welfare Society and Employees Welfare Society on Saturday following an interim order from the High Court Biratnagar on February 7.

A meeting between both parties decided to resume the interview on February 18 and publish the result within one week of the last date of the interview.

Following the agreement teachers, staff and doctors have returned to their duties.

Out of 3,319 positions in the hospital, 1,503 positions are vacant. Of them, a notice was published for the internal promotion of 766 positions. The court has stated that it was lawful.

However, the court has given an interim order to stop the new appointment, which started without the participation of the Public Service Commission, until the case was finally decided.

Prof. Surya Prasad Sangraula, Registrar of the B.P. Koirala Institute of Health Sciences, said that the interview process objected to by the Public Services Commission would not stop at any cost as the court said that it was lawful. He said that they would publish the schedule on February 18 and select members through the Senate.

NPU Gorkhapatra holds condolence meeting on Pandit's demise

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11

Nepal Press Union chapter of Gorkhapatra Corporation organised a condolence meeting on the 13th day of the demise of Shesh Kanta Pandit on Sunday.

Pandit, working as Associate Editor at the Gorkhapatra daily, passed away on January 31 while undergoing treatment for cancer at Mediciti Hospital in Lalitpur.

His colleagues working at the Gorkhapatra Corporation observed a one-minute silence and paid tribute to him by offering flowers in his photograph.

On the occasion, Acting Editor-in-Chief of the Gorkhapatra Shiva Kumar Bhattarai recalled the late Pandit as a diligent and honest staff of the daily. He urged the management to provide needed support to the family of the late Pandit.

General Manager Lal Bahadur Airi also paid tribute to the late Pandit on the occasion.

Corruption weakens nation's...

Prem Kumar Rai, Chief Commissioner of the CIAA, said that the CIAA had been playing an active role in checking corruption and promoting good governance in the nation. Stating that the CIAA received a significant number of complaints related to misuse of public assets in the development and construction works, budget appropriation, subsidy distribution, corruption and others at all three levels of the government, he stressed the need for all to work actively and responsibly to curb corruption.

He said that transparency was not seen in public procurement and construction and the appropriate standards were not followed while formulating the budget and programmes.

He said, "The fight against corruption is not that of the CIAA alone; there is a need for collective efforts as it is a multi-dimensional issue. Every citizen should be the activist for the establishment of good governance." He also urged other responsible bodies to become extra responsible when it comes to fulfilling their legal responsibilities.

Chief Commissioner Rai said that the CIAA was moving ahead with seriousness toward expanding its investigation jurisdiction and making its works more vigorous in its investigations to bring those who were involved in illegal activities into the ambit of legal action.

He said, "The CIAA is formulating the fifth institutional strategic plan to address the issues identified through the review of its fourth institutional strategic plan (2019/020-2023/024)."

He informed that in the recently published Corruption Perception Index of Transparency International, the position of Nepal improved by 1 point, climbing to 35. "However, a country with a score of less than 50 is considered a country with a high risk of corruption, so it is seen that Nepal still has to struggle a lot in corruption control and promotion of good governance," he added.

At the programme, President Paudel launched the CIAA Souvenir-2024.

Similarly, four journalists were awarded with a letter of commendation and a cash prize of Rs. 20,000 each, for their contribution to corruption control and promotion of good governance through news dissemination.

Likewise, the CIAA honoured Rajesh Kumar Das, Deputy Superintendent of Police Prakash Budhathoki, and Deputy Attorney Niranjan Sthapit with the Outstanding Investigator and Outstanding CIAA Service Award carrying Rs. 35,000 and a copper plaque.

Vice President Ram Sahay Prasad Yadav, Chief Justice Bishowambhar Prasad Shrestha, Speaker of the House of Representatives Devraj Ghimire, National Assembly Chair Ganesh Prasad Timilsina, Deputy Prime Minister, lawmakers, high government officials among others, were present on the occasion.

Meanwhile, the 33rd establishment day was celebrated across all seven provinces of the country by organising events.

2023 second hottest year for...

The year commenced with increased monthly maximum temperatures in the initial two months, followed by a period of below-normal maximum temperatures from March to May. June saw the highest deviation from normal temperatures, warmer by plus 2.0 degrees Celsius.

Subsequently, above-normal maximum temperatures persisted from June to December, except for August, which witnessed below-normal temperatures. Monthly minimum temperatures remained above normal throughout the year, except for April and May. Comparing annual average minimum temperatures since 1981, 2023 ranked as the second warmest year.

Rainfall pattern

According to DHM, Nepal received approximately 91.2 per cent of the normal precipitation, totalling around 1570.4 mm for the year. Notable variations were observed across different regions. The northern part of Karnali Province witnessed comparatively lower precipitation levels, with the Dunai station in Dolpa district recording 410.7 mm.

On the other hand, isolated areas of Gandaki Province experienced exceptionally high rainfall, with Lumle station in Kaski district recording the highest total precipitation of 4625.9 mm.

Discrepancies in precipitation levels were evident across various stations, with Khudibazaar recording the highest percentage of normal precipitation (129%) and Janakpur Airport station recording the lowest (51%).

The meteorological data for 2023 underscores the complex climate patterns observed in Nepal, with variations in precipitation and temperature levels across different regions, alongside significant instances of extreme weather events like heat waves.

According to Dr. Pokharel, "Now the country should focus on adaptation because there might be a trend of shifting farming systems. We have been witnessing a short winter season, high-intensity rainfall in a short span of time and winter drought," he added.

Evading VAT is a crime...

Meanwhile, interacting with the local businesspersons after inspecting the Mechi Customs office in Kakadvitta on Sunday, Dr. Mahat said that evading the Value Added Tax (VAT) is a crime. He stated that the VAT is the amount collected from the consumers and that it is a tax that should not be paid from the profit of the businessmen and asked them not to cheat the VAT.

He said that the VAT paid by the customer to the government was put into the pocket by the businessmen. It is natural to complain that the tax has increased, but it is not acceptable to collect VAT from customers and not to pay it to the government.

In order to discourage VAT evasion, effective coordination with all concerned bodies including the local government is necessary, he said.

House...

Nepali Congress General Secretary and Member of Parliament Bishwa Prakash Sharma demanded immediate rescue of Nepali citizens working in the Russian army. Sharma drew the serious attention of the government saying that more than a dozen Nepalis died and three more were arrested.

Former Home Minister Rabi Lamichhane and party president of Rastriya Swantantra Party took a dig at Shrestha saying that many reasons for corruption including the transfer of government lands, and many current problems were the result of the inefficiency of the Home Ministry and its leadership.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Health & Population
Department of Health Services
Management Division
Pachali, Teku, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice of Intention to Award

Date of Notice : 12 February 2024

Pursuant to clause 27(2) and 47(3) of Public Procurement Act 2063, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive lowest bidders have been selected to award the contract as per the Invitation for Bids published on Rising Nepal dated DOHS intends to award the contract to the same.

S. N.	IFB No.	Item	Name of Successful Bidder	Price bid opened date	Total Amount
1	DOHS/G/ ICB-3.2/EDCD/ 2080-81	Procurement of Anti Rabies Vaccine-1ml	M/S Indian Immunologicals Limited Road No. 44, Jubilee Hills, Hyderabad PIN 500033, Telangana State India, Hyderabad India 500033	26 January 2024	INR 34,680,000.00 CIP
2.	DOHS/G/ ICB-3.1/ EDCD/2080-81	Procurement of Anti Rabies Vaccine-0.5 ml	M/S Indian Immunologicals Limited Road No. 44, Jubilee Hills, Hyderabad PIN 500033, Telangana State India, Hyderabad India 500033	26 January 2024	INR 25,740,000.00 CIP
3.	DOHS/G/ICB-16/FWD/2080-81	Procurement of MR Vaccine	Serum Institute of India 212/2, Off Soli Poonawalla Raod, Hadapsar Pune 411028 phone: 912026602219	26 January 2024	USD 5,230,950.00 CIP

NEPAL ELECTRICITY AUTHORITY
(A Government of Nepal Undertaking)

Request for Expressions of Interest (EOI) For Consulting Services of the International Individual Solar with BESS consultant through a consulting entity under the Additional Financing on SASEC Power System Expansion Project

(Date of First Publication: 12th February 2024)

1. Government of Nepal has received grant assistance from Asian Development Bank (ADB) for the Additional Financing on the South Asia Sub-Regional Economic Cooperation (SASEC) Power System Expansion Project. Part of the facility is provided to Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) to fund eligible payment under consultant's services. With the facility, NEA intends to undertake the consulting services through an International Individual Consultant.
2. NEA ("the Employer") now invites eligible International Individual Consultant through a consulting entity to indicate their interest in providing the services. Expression of interest (EOI) will be assessed based on General Qualifications (10%), Project related Experience (80%) and Geographical Competence (10%). Based on the evaluation of submitted proposals, the consultant shall be selected.
3. The details of the package are accessible from ADB's consulting services recruitment notice (http://csrn.adb.org), and interested consultants are encouraged to submit their EOI through ADB's consultant management system (registration and access through http://csrn.adb.org or http://cms.adb.org). The interested Consultants must provide information in the form of CV that shows experience and qualification in the related field with substantiation, description of completed similar assignments, work experience in the related areas, etc. to show their academic, professional and geographical competence to perform the services.
4. The application must be responsive to the requirements mentioned in Terms of Reference. The application should be in sufficient details to be verifiable.
5. The services to be provided by the various consultants are estimated as below. Also, the Consultants are required to have respective experience as follows:

S.No.	Consultant	Person-months	Preferred Requirement
1	International Individual Solar with BESS consultant through a consulting entity (Intermittent)	Eight (8)- Home office (2.5), field office (3.5) and FAT (2)	Solar and BESS Expert shall have preferably Master's Degree in Electrical/Electronics/ Engineering/Solar related Renewable Engineering and preferably more than 10 years of experience in grid tied solar projects. The consultant shall also preferably have more than 5 years of experience in FAT of grid tied solar and preferably more than 5 years of experience in testing and commissioning of the grid tied solar PV projects. Further, they shall preferably have more than 5 years of experience in BESS; preferably more than 3 years' experience in FAT of BESS; preferably more than 3 years of experience in testing and commissioning of the grid tied solar PV projects with BESS.

Further, the Technical support staff at all four sites to support both civil and electrical installation works has been provisioned as Lump sum in the Provisional Sums considering all complete works at each site as one separate Lot.

6. The Consultant(s) will be selected and engaged in accordance with the Guidelines on the Use of Consultants by Asian Development Bank and its Borrowers (March 2013) under the Individual Consultant Selection (ICS) method.
7. Tentative commencement date of the consultant will be 1st April 2024.
8. The Expressions of Interest, EOI shall be delivered through CMS (online) by 27th February 2024. The EOI should be clearly marked with "Expression of Interest for Selection of Consultant for Consulting Services of the International Individual Solar with BESS consultant through a consulting entity under the Additional Financing on SASEC Power System Expansion Project"
   Project Manager
   Karnali Solar Energy Project
   Project Management Directorate, Nepal Electricity Authority
   Kharipati, Bhaktapur, Nepal
   Tel.: +977-1- 620007, E-mail: solarkarnali@gmail.com
9. The interested Consultant(s) may obtain further information at the above address during office hours.
10. NEA reserves the right to reject any or all of the EOIs at any stage without assigning any reason whatsoever and without incurring any liability to the affected applicant(s). NEA will not be responsible for any cost of expenses incurred by the consultants in connection with the preparation or delivery of the EOI.

Notice of Sealed Quotation for Fuel Procurement at Narita, Japan

First Date of Publication: - 27 Jan, 2024
Second Date of Publication: 12 Feb 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation, a fully government owned national flag carrier of Nepal, hereby invites Sealed quotation(s) from interested and qualified fuel suppliers/re-sellers for Into Plane Delivery of Aviation Fuel (ATF) at NRT/RJAA for refueling Nepal Airlines Flights.

AIRPORT (ICAO CODE)	ESTIMATED UPLIFTMENT (TONS/MILLION USG)	CONTRACT PERIOD
Narita International Airport-NRT(RJAA)	111856TONS/3.901282 MILLION USG	01 Mar 2024 to 28 Feb 2026

The detailed information about this Sealed Quotation Invitation can be obtained by visiting Nepal Airlines Corporation Official Website under Notices section.
https://www.nepalairlines.com.np/notices
Your SEALED QUOTATION(S) must reach by 1600 Hrs Nepal Standard Time on 18th Feb 2024 by 1700 Hrs in a sealed envelope and delivered through courier at the following address.

DIRECTOR
OPERATIONS DEPARTMENT, HEAD OFFICE
NEPAL AIRLINES CORPORATION
4TH FLOOR, NAC BUILDING
NEW ROAD GATE, KANTIPATH, KATHMANDU, NEPAL
TEL: +977-1-4222268; FAX: +977-1-1-4225348
E-MAIL: dir.od@nac.com.np

Menuka roped in another Indian project as a playback singer

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11



Singer Menuka Poudel, who was one of the most loved contestants of the Indian singing reality show 'Indian Idol 14', has been roped in for 'Karmaa Meets Kismet', another project as a playback singer.

Menuka had earlier made her debut as a playback singer in a South Indian film titled 'Salaar'.

'Karma Meets Kismat' will be her second Indian project as a playback singer.

Currently, Menuka is in Kathmandu.

After elimination from the show, she journeyed to Nepal via Mechi Bridge and received a grand welcome in her hometown in Jhapa last week.

During her interview with Prime Time HD, Poudel expressed her readiness to sing in any language for film projects.

She also announced her plans to engage in live music performances, including concerts and a world tour alongside Indian Idol, which has already been arranged.

Poudel said that she is touring countries like America, the UK, Mauritius, South Africa, and more.

According to the Indian news agency IANS, this film will be written and directed by Geetanjali Sinha.

The film also features songs by Sonu Nigam and Sadhana Sargam.

According to IANS, Poudel said, "I am deeply moved by the love and blessings that seem to have paved this beautiful path for me.

Being a part of this enriching movie has been an immense blessing, and its story has profoundly inspired me. This romantic Sufi song is a masterpiece that goes straight to the heart, reminding us of love in its purest form."

Sharing why she chose Menuka Poudel for the song, Geetanjali Sinha said, "The honesty and purity in Menuka's voice pulled me to her like a magnet, as per IANS.

Nepali music video made using AI technology

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11



A music video titled 'Timi Je Bana Udaharan Bana', created by using Artificial Intelligence (AI) technology, has been released ahead of Saraswati Puja.

The music video carries a powerful message aimed at inspiring children to become exemplary citizens.

The music video featuring the voices of Pramod Kharel and Dr. Trishala Gurung was released simultaneously from Nepal and America.

Manoj Khadka is the lyricist while Kalyan Singh composed music for the AI-created music video directed by Nawa Dhungel.

The song encouraged students to adopt good habits and inspired people to transcend traditional thinking, which often commands specific professions such as professors, doctors, engineers, or pilots for their children.

Instead, the song encourages them to strive to be good individuals in whatever work, profession or business they engage in.

Lyricist Khadka said that the singer was chosen based on the overall sentiment of the song.

The song aims to make parents feel that they have inspired their children to follow the righteous path, said lyricist Khadka. Khadka, who was born in Pauwadungma Rural municipality of Bhojpur, holds an important position in the American government service.

Khadka, who has gained work experience in various government and non-government sectors in Nepal, has been living in Washington DC.

Scarlett Johansson and Dan Marino have fun with almost being champions

AP
Las Vegas, Feb. 11



Actor Scarlett Johansson and NFL legend Dan Marino come from different professions, but they have two things in common: Both have a sweet tooth and an infatuation with M&Ms.

Johansson and Marino will star in the Super Bowl commercial that will focus on the candy being the comfort fun food while watching the big game. Both will be placed in a humorous scenario around the theme, poking fun at their respective "almost champion" status from her Oscars and his Super Bowl loss. The commercial will also have guest appearances from former NFL players Terrell Owens and Bruce Smith.

Johansson is so much of a Marino fan that she agreed to do the commercial before even knowing M&Ms was the brand behind it. Thankfully, she's a lover of the candy too — particularly the peanut butter version.

"Some creative brain stuck us together," said Johansson, who has starred in the films "Black Widow," "Lucy" and "Asteroid City." "I was pretty excited about it, mostly because I was excited to work with Dan. I didn't want to geek out, but I couldn't wait to meet him. As soon as my agent said Dan Marino's name, I was like 'Yes, this is awesome. What is this for?' "

Johansson added: "This commercial is so exciting. I mean, I'm like a massive peanut butter M&M fan, so that brings me even more excitement." Marino likes the chocolate variety, but he was just as enthused to work with Johansson. He and Johansson didn't mind that the commercial poked a little fun at them.

"Life goes on," said the Hall of Fame quarterback who played 17 seasons with the Miami Dolphins and competed in the 1985 Super Bowl. "I played in one Super Bowl and didn't win. But time passes, and that's not going to happen. I think if we can have fun all together, make a fun Super Bowl commercial, it's OK. Almost champions, the comfort, the fun of doing a Super Bowl commercial. That's perfect for me."

Mary J. Blige, Mariah Carey among Rock Hall nominees for '24



AP
New York, Feb. 11

Mary J. Blige, Mariah Carey, Cher, Lenny Kravitz, the late Sinéad O'Connor and heavy metal's so-called Prince of Darkness are some the 2024 nominees for induction into the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame, a wide musical net that also includes the pop-soul of Sade and Britpoppers Oasis.

Ozzy Osbourne, who led many parents in the 1980s to clutch their pearls with his devil imagery and sludgy music, gets the nod as a solo artist, having already gone into the hall with Black Sabbath. Nominations also were handed to hip-hop duo Eric B. & Rakim, soft rockers Foreigner, singer-guitarist Peter Frampton, alt-rockers Jane's Addiction and Dave Matthews Band, and dance icons Kool & the Gang.

"Continuing in the true spirit of rock 'n' roll, these artists have created their own sounds that have impacted generations and influenced countless others that have followed in their footsteps," said John Sykes, Chairman of the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame Foundation in a statement.

Ten of the 15 nominees are on the ballot for the first time, including Carey, Cher, Foreigner, Frampton, Kool & the Gang, Kravitz, Oasis, O'Connor, Osbourne and Sade. Sade, whose 1980s soft rock hits include "Smooth Operator" and "The Sweetest Taboo," is having a moment, having last year been inducted into the Songwriters Hall of Fame.

Carey, with 19 No. 1 hits on the Billboard Hot 100, Blige with eight multi-platinum albums and nine Grammy Awards, and Cher — the only artist to have a No. 1 song in each of the past six decades — would help boost the number of women in the hall.

Artists must have released their first commercial recording at least 25 years before they're eligible for induction. The induction ceremony will take place in Cleveland this fall.

Nominees will be voted on by more than 1,000 artists, historians and music industry professionals. Fans can vote online or in person at the museum, with the top five artists picked by the public making up a "fans' ballot" that will be tallied with the other professional ballots.

Last year, Missy Elliott, Willie Nelson, Sheryl Crow, Chaka Khan, "Soul Train" creator Don Cornelius, Kate Bush and the late George Michael were some of the artists who got into the hall.

Kartik meets fan who travelled over 1000 km on bicycle

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Feb. 11

Actor Kartik Aaryan recently met with a die-hard fan of his who traveled over 1000 km from Jhansi to meet the star. Recently, a dedicated fan of the actor made the remarkable journey from Jhansi to Mumbai on a bicycle just to meet his idol. Pictures and videos of the Bhool Bhulaiyaa fame meeting the fan outside his house have since gone viral on social media. In the video, the Luka Chuppi actor is seen stepping out of his house to greet the fan. While he attempts to shake hands with the fan, he proceeds to touch his feet as a gesture of respect. Kartik then kindly offers the fan a glass of water.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Leaning into your fantasies and daydreams can be rewarding now. As the impressionable Moon meets mystical Neptune in your 12th House of Contemplation, you might land on a really interesting idea while you're just spacing out.

Taurus: Knowing what you really want could be a challenge right now. While the emotional Moon and theatrical Neptune unite in your 11th House of Community, your peers may be prone to dramatic displays.

Gemini: Your dynamic with a boss or authority figure could be confusing at this moment. Perhaps they rely on you more intensely than you find comfortable. After the observant Moon shifts into your social sector.

Cancer: Someone else's tale of a dramatic spiritual experience could currently get you excited. You might also be a little jealous if you haven't had anything similar happen yourself. Of course, part of the nature of these events is that you can't force them to occur on command.

Leo: A seemingly petty conflict could make you realize you need to define clearer boundaries in one of your close relationships. Permission has potentially been assumed and not articulated for too long, and it's simply not working anymore -- the current provocation.

Virgo: An intense dynamic in one of your close relationships could be overwhelming now. Perhaps the desire to maintain good feelings is so strong that it's hard to say who's responsible when anything bad happens.

Libra: A lack of limits around your responsibilities could sap your energy at the moment. Regardless of your eagerness to get things done, failing to take a break when you need it can lead to burnout.

Scorpio: You're equipped to tell an amazing story today. While the crowd-pleasing Moon and creative Neptune unite in your artistic 5th house, you can spin a narrative that takes on a mythic scale,.

Sagittarius: Your idealized vision of home or family could currently block you from seeing a path forward that would realistically meet your needs. Once the sensitive Moon slides into your expressive 5th house.

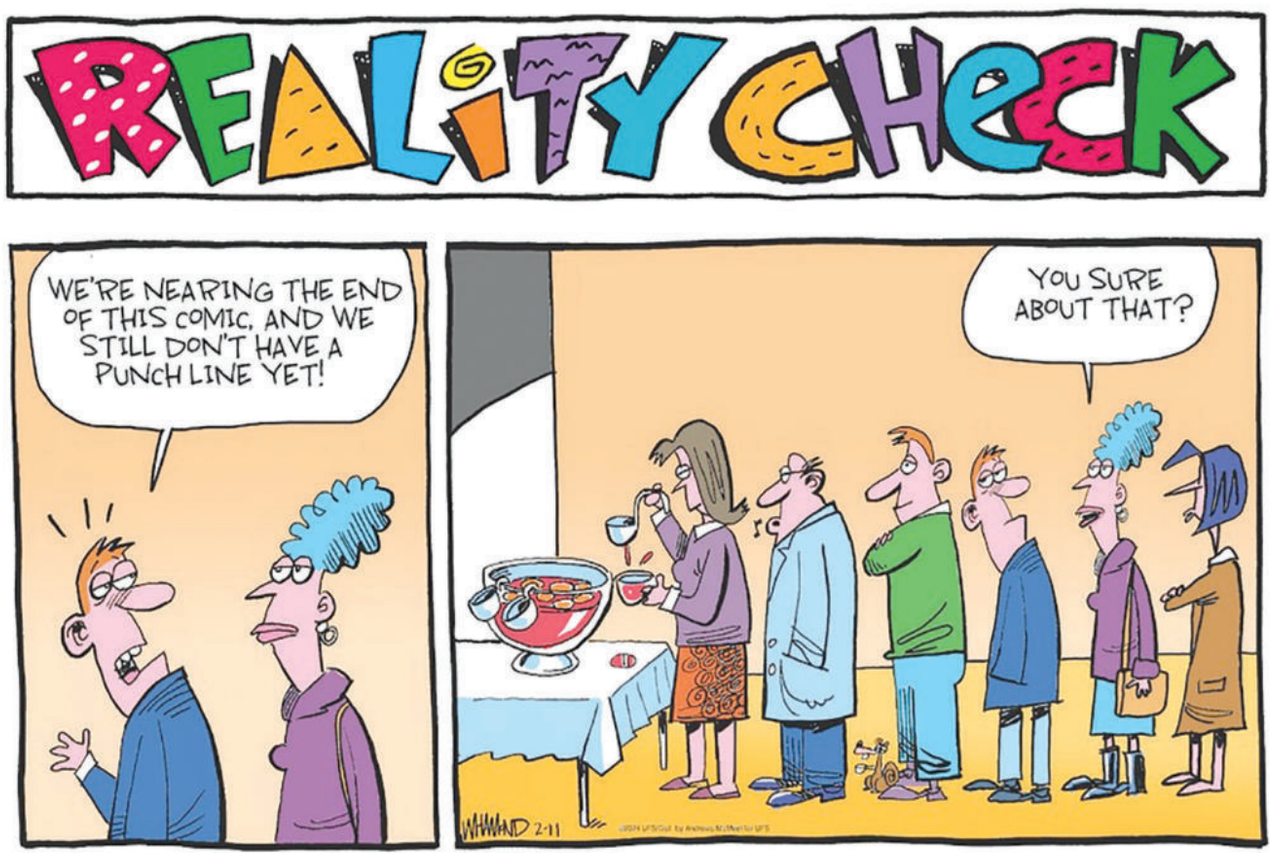
Capricorn: Communicating in an overly emotional way may currently seem easier than going through the proper proc.

Aquarius: You may currently resist pinning down details regarding a money issue. It's possible that you don't want anyone else interfering with your control over a situation, and you suspect that giving them the information.

Pisces: Your ability to shapeshift may be used against you today. While the primal Moon and foggy Neptune merge in your sign, you might wind up carrying the uncomfortable emotions of others.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Athletes Deepak and Rajpura awarded best players of 2079

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11



Photo: Bikash/TRN

Athletes' duo Deepak Adhikari and Rajpura Pachhai bagged the 'Best Male Player of the Year' and 'Best Female Player of the Year' awards respectively at the NSJF Baja Pulsar Sports Award-2079 held in Kathmandu on Sunday.

The duo was selected among the top three nominees in the two categories. Deepak defeated the cricketing duo Aasif Sheikh and Rohit Kumar Paudel while Rajpura competed with Anusha Malla (basketball) and Pushpa Bhandari (athletics).

Deepak won two golds at the Asian Cross-Country Championship alongside other four gold medals and a silver in domestic competitions last year.

Likewise, Rajpura had also won two silver medals, one individually and the other in a team, in the Asian Cross-Country Championship. She also won a silver in the 9th National Games and a gold each in the Dharan 10km Road Race, Nepalgunj 5km marathon and National Athletics. Last year, Rajpura also won golds in half-marathons organised by Kantipur, Pokhara, Lumbini, Ilam, Maipokhari and Chief of the Army Staff (CoAS).

Nevertheless, table tennis player Sikka Suwal Shrestha was voted the 'Peoples' Choice Award'. She won against four other sportspersons – Ananta Tamang (football), Biplov Lal Shrestha (karate), Niruta Thagunna (volleyball), and Rajani Shrestha (bodybuilder).

Sikka is a national champion in doubles. She also won the 2023 Stag Global Champions League. Dev Khanal, who captained the national side to the ICC U19 World Cup recently, won the 'Best Young Player of the Year' award for helping the team qualify for the World Cup.

Chandra Gurung, Nepal's athletics coach, was selected as the 'Best Coach of the Year'. Gurung's coaching led Nepali athletes to win two gold and a bronze in the senior category and two silvers and a bronze in the junior category at the 16th Asian Cross-Country Championship. He also coached the players to win one gold and two bronze medals at the Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujib Dhaka Marathon.

Honorary awards

The country´s veteran weightlifter Rajendra Kumar Pradhan, 69, was awarded the 'Lifetime Achievement Award'. Pradhan, who could neither listen nor speak, was the first Olympian to represent Nepal in weightlifting (1980 Moscow Olympics) and the first national weightlifting champion. Pradhan´s journey has been more than inspiring. Even when deprived of his mother, Pradhan was in Bangkok for the 8th Asian Games in 1978 to represent the country. Further proving he was differently abled, Pradhan started as a coach and trained Nepal´s national weightlifters for the 1990 Asian Games in Beijing, the 8th South Asian Games and the 10th South Asian Games. He was honoured as a central committee member at the Nepal Weightlifting Association, and still, he doesn't feel good unless he takes a round of the weightlifting hall inside Dasharath Rangasala.

Athlete Maiya Bisunkhe received the `Para Athlete Honour Award´. Born without half part of her left hand, her father died when she was 10 years old; until then her mother had left the family. She was then taken care of by the SOS. Slowly, she got involved in sports. She took part in the 2006 National Championship through SOS and won a gold medal. Her chance to represent the country in the 2008 Para Game in Beijing was not fulfilled as Nepal received few quotas. However, she represented Nepal in the 2009 Youth Para Games in Japan, the 2010 Asian Para Games in China and the 2012 London Paralympic Games. "Athletes with disabilities can achieve a lot and the world provides the stage. I expect a proper stage is created by the country for many like me," said Maiya while receiving the award.

The 'Asian Sports Journalists Award' was given to Raymond Chiu of Hong Kong. Chiu has been the chief mentor for the YSR project under the Association Internationale De La Presse Sportive (AIPS) since 2011. He is also a former first vice chairman of AIPS Asia. He is the senior project manager for NowTV and the general manager of Fukusin Production Hub. He has reported in six Olympics starting from the 1988 Seoul Olympics, and four Asian Games. From the 1990 Italia World Cup, Chiu has reported a total of five football World Cups.

Photojournalist Sudarshan Ranjit, who has turned into a sports activist whenever the sector is in need, was awarded the `Special Award´ for his continuous effort towards the sector. Based in Pokhara, there might not be any sports events in the city which has not been captured by Ranjit in the past four decades. Ranjit´s photo of a child playing cricket with Mt. Machhapuchhre as background won the year´s best photo by ICC in 2008. He has been a founding pillar who has still kept the Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup alive. "Over the years, Ranjit´s efforts have never been for economic reasons but a result of his love for sports. NSJF is proud to honour Ranjit with the award," NSJF stated.

Nepal leads Group D with consecutive wins at ACC Women's Premier Cup

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 11



The Nepal women's cricket team has climbed to the top of Group D in the ACC Women's Premier Cup with four points in two matches. In the tournament containing 16 teams divided into four groups, Nepal is in Group D with Hong Kong, Bhutan and the Maldives.

Moreover, Nepal won both of its group matches by eight wickets. Hong Kong was the victim in the opening group match of the tournament on Saturday while Bhutan faced the defeat on Sunday.

Nepal is the only team in Group D with two consecutive wins while the Maldives has lost in both matches it played – against Bhutan on Saturday and Hong Kong on Sunday.

Sita Rana Magar, who took the team to the win against Hong Kong, was the player of the match in the second group match as well since she did the job with both bat and ball.

Winning the toss, Bhutan was asked to bat first by Nepal. While only four wickets fell for Bhutan, they could only add 65 runs on the board by the end of 20 overs.

Opener Ngawang Choden (25 off 50) was Bhutan's highest scorer followed by captain Dechen Wangmo (17 off 21) and Tshering Zangmo (16 off 35).

Nepal's captain Indu Barma, Kabita Joshi, Kabita Kunwar and Sita took a wicket each. Kabita Kunwar, Rubina and Sita were extremely economical as the trio only gave 7, 10 and 8 runs in their spell of four overs respectively.

Sita, who stayed not out at 36 off 38 to chase the target of 94 against Hong Kong, again stood her ground, this time against Bhutan, to chase the paltry target of 66 runs by scoring 32 off 37.

Captain Barma and opener Kabita Kunwar departed in single figures by the end of the fourth over leading Sita to partner with Rubina for the win. The duo chased the target in the 12th over with Rubina adding 17 off 24.

Anju Gurung and Anjuli Ghale took a wicket each for Bhutan.

Nepal will play its final group match against the Maldives on Tuesday. Nepal is eying to compete to lift the trophy by advancing as the group topper after defeating the Maldives.

SNIPPETS

KMC wins Taekwondo tourney

Kathmandu: The Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) Team bagged seven gold medals to emerg as the champions of the 4th Bagmati Province Level Junior Invitational Taekwondo Championship. The winner KMC is also the main Sponsor of the event . The host team, Jaisidewal Youth Club A, finished second with five gold medals, while Godawari Municipality came in third place with three gold medals. Rajul Hang Limbu of Jaisidewal and Sampada Siwakoti of Kageswori Municipality were declared the best male and female fighters of the two-day-long tournament The event was held at Satdobato Taekwondo Academy Lalitpur from February 8-10 and saw 20 teams from 18 municipalities of the Bagmati Province participate..

Liverpool reclaims top spot

London (AFP): Liverpool returned to the Premier League summit with a hard-fought 3-1 win against relegation-threatened Burnley on Saturday after champions Manchester City briefly replaced them at the top. The Anfield side are hunting a record-equalling 20th English top-flight title in Jurgen Klopp's final season in charge but once again have relentless City snapping at their heels. Liverpool were not at their fluent best against Vincent Kompany's men but did enough to get over the line on what Klopp called a "super difficult" day. City, who had earlier beaten Everton 2-0, are two points behind Liverpool with a game in hand as they chase an unprecedented fourth consecutive English top-flight title.

Madrid crush Girona

Madrid (AFP): Jude Bellingham struck twice as leaders Real Madrid took control of La Liga with a punishing 4-0 win over second-placed Girona on Saturday, opening up a five-point cushion. Vinicius Junior drove home the opener and then set up Bellingham for the second as Carlo Ancelotti's side dominated the Catalan minnows, leaving the surprise title contenders reeling. Bellingham tapped in the third after the break from close range but limped off with an ankle problem early in the second half. Rodrygo kept the goals flowing with a fine individual effort as the record 35-time Spanish champions taught Girona, in the top flight for only the fourth year in their history, a compelling lesson.

Maxwell's ton lifts Australia to 34-run victory

AP
Adelaide, Feb. 11

Glenn Maxwell blasted a record-equaling century as Australia beat West Indies by 34 runs on Sunday and took an unassailable 2-0 lead in its three-match Twenty20 series.

Maxwell smashed an unbeaten 120 off 55 balls, with eight sixes and 12 fours, and shared a 92-run stand with Tim David (31 off 14 balls) to propel Australia to 241-4 and the highest T20 international score at Adelaide Oval.

"We're extremely lucky to have (Maxwell) in our team," Australia captain Mitch Marsh said. "He's a match winner, game changer and people come to watch him."

The West Indies chase was derailed by the loss of five wickets in the first seven overs, but a rally led by captain Rovman Powell (63 off 36 balls) and Andre Russell (37 off 16 balls) briefly gave the tourists hope of reeling in the mammoth target.

But the weight of the chase ultimately proved too much as Marcus Stoinis (3-36) and debutant Spencer Johnson (2-39) led Australia's bowlers in restricting the West Indies chase to 207-9 in its 20 overs.

"Yeah, I think the boys show courage, you know, that we would just start aggressive but we kept losing wickets," Powell said. "We also need to get big partnerships just as the Aussies did."

Earlier, Australia slipped to a precarious 64-3 after 6.4 overs after being asked to bat first, with Josh Inglis (four), Marsh (29 off 12 balls) and David Warner (22 off 19 balls) all holing-out playing expansive shots.

Maxwell started slowly with his first four runs coming off five balls, before his innings exploded into life with a rush of boundaries.

He shared an 82-run stand with Stoinis (16 off 15 balls) and then a 92-run partnership with Tim David, which reaped 25 runs from the final over bowled by Russell.

Maxwell's century came off 50 balls and was the fastest hundred in a T20 international in Australia — beating South African Rilee Rossouw's 52-ball effort against Bangladesh during the 2022 World Cup.

It was also Maxwell's fifth T20 international century, equaling the record held by India's Rohit Sharma.

Qatar retains Asian Cup with Afif hat-trick

AFP
Doha, Feb. 11



Hosts Qatar retained the Asian Cup with a 3-1 win on Saturday against surprise packages Jordan as Akram Afif scored a hat-trick of penalties. It was a fitting final act to a month of football that began with 24 teams and witnessed a series of dramatic games and plenty of goals.

It will also help dispel the memories of Qatar's 2022 World Cup, when they lost all three games, the worst record of any host in the competition's history. The 27-year-old Afif was the hero, holding his nerve once from the penalty spot in the first half and, after under dogs Jordan equalised, twice more in the second period.

He was named player of the tournament and finished top scorer with eight goals.

His team-mates threw him in the air at the final whistle.

"It is not about the technique or the angle," said Afif, asked how he was able to score three penalties under pressure in front of 86,492 spectators at Lusail Stadium.

"It's about the feeling that the team and people are behind me."

Jordan were in their first Asian Cup final and contesting the biggest match in their history.

Ranked 87th in FIFA's world rankings, 29 places below their opponents, they fell behind midway through the first half when Afif slotted home after being brought down in the box. Qatar deserved their half-time lead but Jordan roared back to equalise through Yazan Al-Naimat's smart finish.

Jordan were level however for just six minutes, Afif scoring once again from a penalty after the referee was advised by VAR to go to his pitch-side monitor. This time there was to be no Jordan comeback and Afif capitalised again from the spot for his hat-trick in injury time, again after a VAR intervention.

Magic trick

Qatar came into the final attempting to become the fifth team to lift back-to-back Asian titles.

Qatar parachuted in the Spaniard Tintin Marquez to replace Carlos Queiroz just a month before the Asian Cup, in a major gamble that paid off handsomely.

"I took charge just before the tournament but what was most important was that I knew the players and they implemented my ideas fast and executed my plans," said Marquez, who has a decade-long association with Qatari football and managed one of their club sides.

Surprises

The competition, originally scheduled to take place in China last year but postponed and moved because of Covid, will be remembered for shocks -- even if the final failed to produce one last one.

Pre-tournament favourites Japan were dumped out in the quarter-finals by Iran, who subsequently lost to Qatar in a five-goal thriller. Jordan reached the semi-finals for the first time and blew away South Korea, leaving coach Jurgen Klinsmann clinging precariously onto his job.

Tajikistan made the quarter-finals on their Asian Cup debut, while Palestine also made a piece of history by reaching the knock-out rounds for the first time.

WEATHER

Monday

Sunrise at 6:44 am, Sunset at 5:52 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Monday)

Partly to generally cloudy in Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province along with the hilly regions of the country and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 21-23 Rain Probability: 0%

Sunday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	25.4	3.8	0.0
Dadeldhura	17.5	4.3	0.0
Dhangadi	26.7	8.2	0.0
Birendranagar	24.9	6.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	26.2	9.0	0.0
Jumla	16.2	-5.4	0.0
Ghorahi	24.8	7.8	0.0
Pokhara	24.3	9.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	26.0	6.3	0.0
Simara	26.0	7.5	0.0
Kathmandu	22.6	4.7	0.0
Okhaldhunga	20.7	8.5	0.0
Taplejung	19.2	5.5	0.0
Dhankuta	24.9	8.8	0.0
Biratnagar	26.7	8.0	0.0
Jomsom	12.1	-3.0	0.0*
Dharan	28.0	11.5	0.0*
Lumle	18.5	5.8	0.0*
Janakpur	28.4	8.0	0.0*
Jiri	17.0	-0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 12, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.56	Rs. 133.16
Euro	1	Rs. 142.95	Rs. 143.60
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.39	Rs. 168.15
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 151.54	Rs. 152.23
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.48	Rs. 86.87
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.49	Rs. 98.93
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.47	Rs.98.92
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.88	Rs. 8.92
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.43	Rs. 18.51
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.35	Rs. 35.51
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.35	Rs. 36.51
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.69	Rs. 3.71
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.09	Rs. 36.26
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.82	Rs. 27.95
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.96	Rs. 10.00
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.67	Rs. 12.73
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.18	Rs. 19.26
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.52	Rs. 432.46
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.64	Rs. 353.23

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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